Power Corrupting — Part 2: The Rise

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Power Corrupting — Part 2: The Rise

by TurtleTotem

Summary

Catra's determination to make it on her own—no matter what it takes—have left her hated and feared and alone. She's unable to even use clean mana anymore, and her body is already beginning to break down as a result. It's far too late for her to turn back... isn't it?

Chapter 1

Lurking in a stairwell was a great way to get killed at the Scholomance—not that there was any shortage of those—but there weren't a lot of places to hide where Catra could keep watch on her target.

"You'll tell me if you see anything sneaking up on me, right?" she muttered into the bizarre little contraption perched on her ear. It had three heads on thin filament necks—two with eyes and one with ears—and clamped itself in place with tiny metal claws. Exactly the sort of artifice that was prone to wandering off to become a mal, but for now it was obeying its maker's commands.

"Of course I will." The voice, tinny and faint, came out of the head with the ears. "This would all be such a waste of resources if you got killed before you could bring me the mana amplifier!"

From most students, that remark would have been mocking or even threatening. From Entrapta, though, it was probably exactly what it sounded like, blithe and forthright.

"He's coming out!" Catra whispered, easing back from the crack in the door so he wouldn't see her. But Arrow Boy didn't even glance her way, instead knocking on the door next to his. After some muffled conversation, that door opened too, and out came the pink-haired enclave princess Adora hung out with so much these days. Though she hung out with the boy almost as much, really. That was not why Catra had chosen his room to burgle, but she could admit it was a nice bonus.

The two of them disappeared down the hallway toward the cafeteria, and Catra darted out of the stairwell to Bow's door.

"Don't touch it yet!" Entrapta exclaimed in her ear.

"I'm not!" Catra raised her hands as proof, but both tiny bead-sized seeing heads were trained on Bow's door.

"Oh, he's very good at this," Entrapta said, as her artifice fed her some kind of mana-vision view of the door—and whatever alarms and traps Bow had put on it. "Not as good as me, but still. I wish he was graduating this year, maybe we could be allies!"

"After you steal from him?"

"Well, maybe he won't find out about that. Okay, Catra, here's what you need to do."

It was a rocky process, translating what Entrapta saw and advised into spells Catra could cast. Arrow Boy had two wards on his door, one a simple zapper that likely connected to some trinket or amulet he carried, the other a fiendishly complex thing designed to confuse anything with a mind and send it wandering the other direction.

"He had help with that one," Entrapta judged. "That's senior-level incantations work."

"The joys of having enclaver friends," Catra muttered, then bent her mind to casting the spells that would get her past both wards.

When she finally managed it, she was so distracted by relief that she almost stepped right into a booby trap.

"Catra, freeze!" Entrapta cried, and she did, one foot in the air and one hand still on the doorknob. "Look down."

Below Catra's hovering foot was a gleaming golden plate with DANGER written across it. A warning to any of his friends who came in unexpectedly, she supposed.

"I told you it was probably booby-trapped!" Entrapta squawked. "Don't move a muscle. Does the plate seem to be connected to anything?"

"Yeah," Catra said shortly. "Probably the big ol' crossbow currently pointing a flaming arrow at me."

"If it's a crossbow, it would be a bolt, not an arrow."

"I don't care what it is! I want it disabled!"

"Hold on, let me… see if I can… hmm…" There followed a great deal of humming and mumbling. Catra's leg was starting to tremble with the effort of keeping it in the air, but if she moved—even to back away—it might set off the trap. Even though she hadn't touched the plate yet, she very much doubted Bow always left a crossbow floating in the air, much less one actively on fire. She'd clearly already tripped something.

"Entrapta," Catra singsonged impatiently.

"Keep your pants on!"

"Oh, sorry, am I being too demanding? While I risk my life out here, and you sit safely in your room?"

Entrapta made a thoughtful sound. "Was that sarcasm?"

"Yes!"

"Well, you are the one taking the physical risk, but you're also the one getting the most reward," Entrapta pointed out cheerfully. "All I get to do is *look* at the mana amplifier."

Catra gritted her teeth. She absolutely had not anticipated needing a mana amplifier, only a few weeks after she filled all her mana-storage crystals to the brim. And she did still have plenty of mana… malia… whatever, glowing merrily in her trunk. But she'd been running through it faster than she ever expected.

Turned out it took a lot of power to watch her own back all the time—to keep up shields everywhere she went, a weapon in one hand and a combat spell in the other. Even with all that, she was only one person; a single lapse of attention, a single glance in the wrong direction instead of the right one, and something could still take her out. There was a reason that even the strongest students kept friends around to eat with, walk with, go with to the

bathroom. And a reason that even the lamest losers could find someone willing to do that for *them*, in exchange for the same in return.

But not Catra. No one trusted a maleficer to watch their back. Which was fine, because Catra didn't trust anyone to watch hers, either. Not anymore. Catra could take care of herself.

But she did need *mana* to do it. And the amplifier Bow had built would help her stretch her supply a lot further, without having to hunt other students as much.

So she was lucky as hell to have convinced one of Bow's artificer classmates to help with this little heist, no matter how annoying Entrapta could be. And doubly lucky that Entrapta didn't even want the amplifier, just a chance to look it over closely enough to build one herself.

"All right, I think I've got it," Entrapta said in her ear. "Take Cerberus off your ear and set him on that shelf—can you reach it?"

"I think so."

"Okay. After that, back away and close the door again. It won't set anything off. I don't think. Then knock on the door and wait to be invited in."

"What? By whom?"

"By me!"

"It's not your room, and you're not even in it!"

"Trust me, Catra, I know what I'm doing! More or less."

Catra wanted nothing more than to shake Entrapta by the shoulders, but she had little choice but to try her instructions. Carefully she took the three-headed artifice off her ear, stretched

her arm out to the side to nudge it onto the bookshelf, and stepped back, pulling the door closed.

Anyone could have been in the hallway, ready to snitch on her or stab her in the back. Any*thing* could have been there, delighted to find a potential meal separated from the pack. But after a heart-pounding moment, claws and spells at the ready, she concluded she was alone.

She turned and, feeling like an idiot, knocked on Bow's door.

"Come in!" called Entrapta's muffled voice, still tinny and small through the artifice, straining for volume.

Hesitantly, Catra opened the door again.

The pressure plate was gone, nowhere in sight. The crossbow was hung innocently on the opposite wall, with no indication it had ever menaced her with a flaming arrow. Bolt. Whatever.

Catra reattached Cerberus to her ear. "Incredibly, that worked."

"Oh, good." Entrapta's voice held entirely too much relief for Catra's peace of mind. "Do you see the amplifier?" The two heads with eyes were peering eagerly around the room.

"I doubt he would leave it sitting in the middle of the floor." Though mana amps *could* be massive, most were designed to be worn, which meant there were a lot of places the kid could put it. Hopefully, he felt secure enough with his alarms and booby traps not to bother actively *hiding* it.

Like any Scholomance dorm, the room was small, maybe even a shade smaller than average. Unlike most, it was crowded with stuff—mostly various artifices in various states of construction, and the accompanying piles of tools and supplies. Catra itched to just grab everything she could carry and run for it. She could be a very wealthy girl with even a fraction of Arrow Boy's hoard.

But she could never fence that much stuff without word getting around that she was the one behind the theft, and that would bring all Arrow Boy's enclaver friends down on her head. She was much more likely to get away with stealing just the amplifier.

Very carefully, touching nothing she didn't have to, Catra searched the shelves, the desk, the piles of machinery. Minutes ticked by, and she fought panic. Eventually Bow would come back from dinner, and then she'd be *lucky* to escape empty-handed. And what if the amp wasn't here at all? What if he'd already turned it in for whatever assignment he'd built it for, or was wearing it himself?

But finally her gaze caught on the telltale brassy cones of a mana amplifier, spaced evenly around a leather armlet and dangling from the switch of the mana-lamp on his desk.

"Oh, that's brilliant," Entrapta cooed in her ear as Catra grabbed the thing with a deep huff of relief. "Like a lot of artificers, he's chosen multiple small contact points instead of concentrating the power in one unwieldy cone, but in this case—"

"You can tell me all about it once I get out of here." Amplifier in hand, she ducked out the door, closing it carefully—

Click. Click. Click. The amplifier was ticking in her hand.

Catra's eyes widened. "Entrapta, why is it doing that?"

"Uh-oh…"

Catra didn't wait to find out what that meant. She turned and chucked the mana amp down the hallway.

It exploded before it even hit the floor.

Entrapta would tell her all about it later, how the amplifier used all the mana it had absorbed from Bow—thankfully not very much yet—to self-destruct as soon as unauthorized hands took it outside the dorm room. In the moment, Catra only cared about

the fact that a fireball was swiftly filling the hallway where she stood.

Fortunately, throwing fire (or lightning, or paralysis spells) at Catra had been one of her foster mother's favorite hobbies. Catra had written her Wet Blanket spell when she was ten; it was heavy-handed and crude, but it got the job done. She flung it over the explosion, crushing out every atom of oxygen.

For a moment, she just stood panting in the hallway, blinking fiery afterimages out of her eyes. The blackened remains of the mana amplifier smoked resentfully.

"You saved me."

Catra nearly jumped out of her skin at the unexpected voice. At the other end of the hallway, through a haze of smoke, she saw a student—a girl, immensely tall and broad-shouldered, with a scorpion tail and pincers in place of hands. A chimeric, like Catra herself.

"You saved me," the chimeric girl said again, her voice—initially blank with shock—now moving toward breathless gratitude. "You could have escaped, but you turned back and saved me."

Absolutely none of that was true. "Uh… it really wasn't…"

"Oh, yeah, I'm sure it was nothing," the girl was hurrying toward her now, skirting the smoking bits of amplifier, "for someone on your skill level! You know, everyone says not to trust you, but I've always thought you were just misunderstood. I was there that day, do you remember? I pulled out a chair for you!"

Catra almost asked 'what day?' but frankly, there was only one time she could remember anyone (other than Adora) pulling out a chair for her. The day she confronted Adora about leaving her mana crystals drained, and enjoyed a brief moment of public solidarity. She narrowed her eyes at the girl, recognition dawning. "Huh."

"Well, obviously I owe you one. I, uh, I don't have a lot to offer…" The chimeric girl laughed nervously, scratching the back of her head with one pincer. "But I'm brave! And loyal! And I give good hugs! So, how can I repay you?"

Catra felt her fangs slowly glide into view as she smiled.

The next day at breakfast, Catra drew a couple of double-takes as she took a seat, not alone in a corner, but at a very decent table between two senior enclavers. Well, semi-enclavers; Scorpia's enclave had collapsed, taken out by a mawmouth during her freshman year, and Entrapta came from one of the rare natural enclaves, one barely big enough for her parents and a few retainers. Neither had the power and status usually associated with enclave membership—but both had access to the mana pools built by past generations of the enclave, and that was enough to make them worth befriending.

Allying with, Catra corrected herself. *Not even that, just… eating at a table with*.

At another table, not far away, Sparkles and her hangers-on were comforting a despondent-looking Bow about his lost artifice; Catra could make out the words "amplifier" and "security" and "explosion." She whispered an eavesdropping spell and listened in closer.

"—intended it to disintegrate, not blow up in a fireball," Bow was saying. "At least it doesn't seem to have killed anyone."

"Not even the thief," Glimmer muttered, looking not at all pleased.

"Yes, Glimmer, not even the thief. I don't want to kill *anyone*."

"Who are we killing?" Adora's voice was breezy as she took a seat at the table.

Catra immediately cut off the spell and looked the other way.

Her gaze landed on Scorpia's plate, piled high with enough food for two and a half people. Three, at the Scholomance. "Wow."

Scorpia laughed nervously. "I'm a big girl! Takes a lot of fuel to run this tank, huh?" She flexed her biceps, nearly knocking a passing student over with her pincer. "Besides, I have a really fast metabolism. *You're* a chimeric, you know how it is!"

That was true enough. Most chimerics—wizards born so steeped in magic that they manifested fantastical animal traits—had fast metabolisms, a distinct disadvantage at the Scholomance. Though thanks to her foster mother, Catra had arrived already accustomed to never having quite enough food.

"At least we don't have to wear glamours here," Catra said. Glamour spells, which gave not just the illusion of a normal appearance but the temporary sort-of reality of it, were a necessity for any chimeric outside the walls of an enclave.

"That is a big relief," Scorpia agreed. "Though sometimes I do anyway, just to give myself hands." She clicked her pincers, which Catra had already thought must make classwork difficult.

"Well, that's one thing I can do," Catra said. "Hand things, I mean. Sometimes. To pay you back for the mana."

"Oh, you don't need to!"

"Yeah, yeah, I saved your life. But for next time. Assuming you're cool with having a next time?"

Scorpia gave a sheepish smile. "Well, it's better if I'm not, right?"

Catra laughed. "Now you're getting it!"

It had taken some doing, last night, to make Scorpia understand that she couldn't freely give her mana to Catra, because Catra couldn't *use* it that way. (Very, very bad sign, yes, but nevertheless the reality.) Her usual malia-pulling tactics of consent-under-duress or consent-willfully-misinterpreted wouldn't

work; Scorpia was too willing. They had to settle on a more physical method—spilling blood. Only a scratch this time, already half-healed. Unlike Adora's hand, which had been in a bandage for two weeks.

"You know that's poisoned, right?" Entrapta piped up suddenly.

Catra froze with a spoonful of mashed potatoes halfway to her mouth. Peering down at her plate, she realized that the tiny specks in the potatoes were black, not brown, and therefore not bits of peeling. "Shit! Scorpia's already eaten hers—"

"Oh, I'm immune to most poisons!" Scorpia said brightly. "Side effect of having my own, I guess." She waved her scorpion tail meaningfully.

"That reminds me," Entrapta said, looking up from where she'd been cutting her food up into small pieces, "do you think I could get a sample of your venom? I have an alchemy assignment coming up about synthesizing antidotes, and I'd rather experiment with something non-fatal."

"Don't give it to her for free," Catra said before Scorpia, already cheerfully opening her mouth, could speak.

"Of course I'll make you some of the antidote once I've got it," Entrapta offered. "Even if you don't need it yourself, you can sell it—especially if I can generalize it to all paralytics, which is what I'm hoping."

"I'd like some of that, too," Catra said eagerly. "I can trade you a really good spell for purifying liquids."

"Ooh, yes!"

They shook on it, and bent back to their meals, Catra carefully eating around the mashed potatoes.

She hadn't gotten the mana amplifier, and her strictly-independent lifestyle wasn't sustainable without it. But in its place she'd

acquired some… mutually useful acquaintances, and that might be more valuable, in the long run. And she'd found and formed those connections all by herself.

She didn't need Adora. She never had.

Chapter 2

But sometimes—one fucking important time—Adora needed *her*.

They'd scarcely spoken, in the two months since Catra stole most of Adora's mana and left her unconscious on the gym floor. She'd interrupted Catra's malia hunts a couple of times, encounters that involved a lot more violence than conversation. Several times they'd caught each other staring from across the library, classroom or cafeteria, turning quickly away without acknowledgement. Once, Adora sent Glimmer to ask for some trinket she'd left in Catra's room. Catra pretended to speak only Portuguese, her expression polite and innocent as she told her to *Vá morrer em um incêndio, e leve Adora com você*, until Glimmer snarled in frustration and left.

And then, one quiet Friday evening, when Catra was fiddling with a flower-growing spell for an assignment—not at all her wheelhouse—she heard a ruckus in the hallway outside her room.

Smart students, students who wanted to live, did not investigate disturbances. They ran the other way, or stayed put in the relative safety of their dorms. So Catra stood still with her scrap-metal knife at the ready, heart pounding over the sounds of screams and running, of the whistles and pops and detonations of spells. It did not even cross her mind to step outside into whatever horror movie was happening in the hallway.

Until one terrified voice, barely recognizable as Glimmer's, screamed, *"Adora, no!"*

Catra gritted her teeth. Easy to figure that Adora was about to get herself killed doing something heroically stupid, right on the other side of that wall. But that had nothing to do with her at all so *why was she opening her door?*

Sure enough, Adora was charging at something at the other end of the hall, bellowing aggression, sword swinging. Other students

—an unusual number of them for the area—were scattering out of her path. But Catra couldn't see what mal Adora was chasing. And her expression was… odd.

She wasn't chasing a mal, Catra realized with a chill. She was chasing *the kids*.

She'd cast shields across the ends of the hallway so no one could escape, and was using a buckler of pure mana to catch and disperse the defensive spells rained down on her by her frantic… prey. That was the only word for the pack of terrified freshmen and sophomores she'd trapped in the hallway. A couple were in pools of blood on the floor, though at least one of those was moving. Several more bore wounds that would likely prove fatal if not treated quickly.

Glimmer and her Indonesian friend, Mermista, stood outside the nearest shield, trying to break through it. Glimmer's face was a mess of tears, Mermista's smeared with blood from a cut in her hair.

Glimmer shouted Adora's name over and over, but Adora, gold hair flying like a tattered flag as she turned to slash at one kid after another, took no notice. Her eyes were bloodshot in a mask of deep and violent rage, an expression Catra had never seen on Adora's face in all their lives.

Then a short, freckled kid tried to dodge past her, and the expression shifted to something worse—a horrible, unholy glee. She raised her sword—

Catra had half a second to realize that the boy was dodging *toward her open door*, as the only possible place to go, and that he wasn't going to make it. And that whatever hideous thing was piloting Adora's body was going to barrel right through him and into her dorm room.

She snatched the kid inside and slammed the door, feeling Adora's weight crash into it with a roar.

"You," Catra snarled at the freckled boy, now sprawled on her floor, "sit right there and don't touch anything!"

He managed to nod, in between gasping for breath and shaking like a leaf.

Catra turned back to her closed door, which was vibrating as Adora either pounded on it or tried to dis-embed her sword from it, or both. After a moment, the door stopped moving, and the screaming of the trapped kids resumed with fresh vigor.

Those trapped kids, and Adora's devastation when she realized what she'd done to them, and the high chance of Adora *never* realizing because she'd gotten herself killed in self-defense, possibly by her own friends as soon as they got through the shield —none of that was Catra's problem.

Which was why it was *so stupid* for her to pick up her sleeping-spell flute and step out into the hallway, closing the door on Freckle Boy behind her.

The sound of the door made Adora turn toward her, wild-eyed and grinning, looking less like Adora by the second.

For a moment Catra was sitting in the library with Adora beside her, discussing the flute assignment, that last day before everything went to hell. In the end she hadn't combined the flute with her incantations assignment after all, which was just as well; she didn't have to chant three verses in Quechua before she lifted the flute to her lips and started to play.

It didn't have to be any particular song, but a lullaby seemed most appropriate, and that kind of thing mattered in magic. She played the first one to come to mind, eerily sweet and gentle for the context.

You are my sunshine, my only sunshine…

Adora advanced on her, her teeth too sharp, veins red and bulging in her arms and hands and eyes.

You make me happy when skies are gray

Adora staggered slightly as the spell started kicking in. It damn well ought to work fast; Catra was pouring malia through it like Niagara Falls.

You'll never know, dear, how much I love you

Adora shook her head like a wet dog and lunged forward again, sword level with Catra's heart. Catra closed her eyes.

So please don't take my sunshine away.

A long pause, and then the clatter of a blade dropping to the floor. Catra opened her eyes.

Adora stood swaying, her expression disoriented and sleepy and indefinably *Adora* again. She squinted into Catra's face as if trying to see through fog.

"Oh!" Her voice was dreamy, a loopy smile stealing across her blood-spattered face. "Hi, Catra!"

Then she collapsed to the floor.

The shields at either end of the hallway blinked out of existence. The kids scarpered, hauling their wounded friends, while Glimmer and Mermista rushed to Adora's side. Both kept glancing warily at Catra.

"She's alive," Mermista murmured to Glimmer, fingers against Adora's neck.

Catra tucked the flute into her back pocket and dusted off her hands. "She'll wake up in about an hour. By then you'd better have that mindworm she's hosting taken care of, or you'll be right back where you started."

"Mindworm?" Glimmer repeated.

"She's been acting funny lately, right? A little touchy, bad-tempered? Probably brushed it off as stress? Yeah, mindworm."

"How do we kill it without killing her?" Mermista asked.

"How should I know?" Catra yanked open her door, and jerked a thumb over her shoulder, evicting Freckle Boy without a word. Then slammed the door behind her, and slid down to the floor to wait for her hands to stop trembling.

"It was self-defense, that's all," Catra said, keeping her voice a bored drawl. "She was right outside my door—not that surprising, her room's only four down from mine—and I like not having a sword in my guts, thank you."

Adora's berserker mindworm episode was the talk of the school, of course, and Catra's takedown of it scarcely less so. Adora had reportedly survived having the mindworm extracted, but hadn't come back out in public yet.

"You didn't have to open your door," Entrapta pointed out, without looking up from her plants. Apparently, at her induction, Entrapta had brought in packets of seeds for a variety of hardy, quick-growing water plants. Now one entire wall of her dorm was a meticulously-tended hydroponics bay, and she could "cheat" with comparatively-ethical malia in a way other Scholomance students could hardly dream of. Catra, sprawled on a cushion under the plants' heat lamp, was deeply jealous.

"Why do you bother with all this?" she had asked Entrapta upon first seeing the plants. "Don't you have an enclave mana pool?"

"Yes, but there's not much in it," Entrapta said matter-of-factly. "My enclave's been too small for too long. I'm saving it all for graduation if I can."

Huh. And Scorpia, Catra thought, might not be as well off as she'd assumed, either. There'd been no one else contributing to her enclave's pool for four years now.

"Of course she opened the door," Scorpia was saying. "I keep telling you, Catra's a hero under all that grumping and groaning."

Catra felt her hackles rise like they always did when Scorpia started fawning like this.

"Besides," Scorpia said, "you and Adora grew up together, right, Catra? I know you're not close anymore, but I'm sure you still care whether—"

"I wouldn't care if Adora dropped dead on my shoes," Catra snapped.

Entrapta finally looked up from her pruning. "Then why *did* you get involved?"

"Because…" Catra frantically cast her mind around for a reason, and felt a few half-baked ideas she'd been toying with fall into place. "Because of Mermista. She and Sparkles were gonna break through that shield any minute, and get themselves killed. And that would have interfered with my plans for Mermista and Jakarta enclave."

"Plans?" Scorpia perked up. "What plans?"

"Big plans," Catra said, her gaze drifting over the greenery Entrapta so devotedly watered and tended and talked to, while never hesitating to rip out its mana as needed, and plant more to cover the dead spots. "Plans that mean *none* of us will have to worry about mana for a long, long time."

Chapter 3

When Catra got the drop on an enclaver, she usually broke their power-sharer first thing, so that they couldn't summon endless resources to fight her off with. But one evening, a month or so before Adora's mindworm infection, she had nabbed a kid from Jakarta enclave—and things went a little differently.

"Take it." The kid—Fadil, she found out later—pulled the watch-like device off his wrist and held it out, trembling and on the verge of tears. "Please j-just take my power-sharer. You don't have to hurt me."

"The hell?" Catra snatched the power-sharer out of his hand while she had the chance, but—"This thing won't work for me, you know that!"

"Yeah it will. It's not locked."

"What? Why?" Every enclave locked their power-sharers. Only members of the enclave—sometimes not even all of them—knew how to authorize a new user.

Fadil sniffled and wiped his sleeve across his face. "Couple years ago, the only kid who knew the authorization spell died. It was a whole big mess. So they're all unlocked now."

Fully expecting some kind of trap, Catra tugged lightly at the power she could feel simmering inside the sharer—and nearly dropped the device as mana flowed like a river of light into her veins, smooth and free and abundant. Mana, not malia, so she'd have to "launder" it through Scorpia or maybe trade it to Entrapta for something else, but—free and easy power.

She'd taken a very nice chunk from the Jakarta mana pool before reluctantly giving the power-sharer back to Fadil; locked or not, she'd never get away with keeping it, not without bringing the enclave down on her head. But now she knew that the Jakarta

mana pool was open for the taking, and—once she finished muddling Fadil's memory—nobody knew that she knew that.

She'd been thinking about it ever since.

"Oh, that's pretty. Where'd you get that?" Scorpia peered over Catra's shoulder at the cuff bracelet—gold with a tiger's eye stone—that she was turning over and over in her hands, under the strongest light she could muster at her desk.

"Traded an enclaver my shoes," Catra said shortly. She had always hated wearing shoes, and lost the habit entirely here, where there was no cold weather and no rocks underfoot.

Scorpia snorted. "Must have been nice to have enough weight allotment to spare for jewelry."

"Ah, but it isn't just jewelry. This is an artifice. A variety of spell-holder." Catra held the bracelet up for Scorpia to see; she tapped it thoughtfully with the tip of a pincer.

"Huh. What spell is it holding?"

Catra waved a dismissive hand. "Some kind of glamour, I think, but it's almost worn away. I'll be replacing it with this." She pointed down at her spellbook. The spell she'd written covered an entire page, front and back, even copied down as small as she could write legibly. It had taken a dozen note-paper drafts to get it right. If it *was* right.

"Wow," Scorpia said. "That looks complicated. And expensive."

"It is." Catra took a breath. "It really, really is."

Scorpia bit her lip doubtfully. "What does it do?"

"That's for me to know and nobody to find out."

"Oh, is it for the big plan? Your big secret plan?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Yes, it's for the *big secret plan*."

Scorpia looked at her expectantly, but Catra just drummed her fingers on the desk, staring moodily into the void reflected in the nearby mirror. In her peripheral vision sat her box of mana crystals, most of them currently full. She'd fought *so hard* to get them full. And installing this spell into the bracelet would empty almost all of them. It was a deeply, insanely risky investment.

But the very difficulty she'd faced getting that power cache was the reason she needed to do this. If it worked—and by God she'd make it work—those crystals would scarcely go dark before they found themselves topped up again, just like Entrapta planting new sprouts over the dead spots in her little garden. Catra would never have to worry about having enough mana again. She'd even have enough to share with her friends. Enough that she might not need a graduation alliance.

Entrapta and Scorpia were both seniors, graduating in just a few months. Entrapta was already in an alliance; as a truly first-class artificer, it hadn't been hard. Her allies—one from Sacramento enclave, the other an indie from Australia—seemed to think she was a freak, but that didn't matter if they could get each other out alive. Entrapta was planning to approach her alliance about taking on Scorpia, as well, on the basis of her pure strength and size. Scorpia had had an alliance with three others last year, but since then two had died, and the third took a better offer. Scorpia still gave sad looks to the corridor wall where allies traditionally wrote their names together, and where she and the three others were crossed out.

Catra didn't want to depend on anyone else for survival, not for a second. But even a maleficer, according to common wisdom, couldn't get through graduation alone. If Catra could make this plan work, she'd never have to yank mana from the unwilling again. People would slowly stop being distrustful and afraid of her. Someone, maybe Lonnie and Rogelio (and Kyle, if the others insisted), might be willing to ally with her. They didn't have to be friends, they just had to get each other out alive.

If not, she would have the power to, just maybe, prove common wisdom wrong.

She would do whatever it took to get out of here alive. And once she did, it would all be worth it. Everything she had done would be worth it.

It took a few days to find Mermista without any of the other "princess alliance" hanging around, but Catra couldn't risk someone else stepping in. She had to deal with Mermista directly.

Finally she spied her target in Jakarta's staked-out spot in the library, sitting only with other members of her enclave—Fadil not among them, fortunately. She didn't want to test her memory-work that directly.

"Mermista," she called, sauntering up to her group. She stopped just far enough away to avoid alarming any trigger-happy enclavers.

Mermista eyed her distrustfully, but didn't immediately run her off. The sleeping flute incident had bought Catra an audience with Her Majesty, it seemed. But the moment stretched with Mermista not saying a word, just raising her eyebrows at Catra.

Finally Catra rolled her eyes, and said sweetly, "Lovely weather we're having."

"And here I thought you only spoke Portuguese."

Catra surprised herself with a genuine laugh. "And how *is* Glimmer since I saved both of your lives?"

"Go ask Glimmer yourself, I dare you."

Catra laughed again, ruefully. "As fun as it would be to spin up Little Miss Sparkles, I have other things to do today."

"Better get to doing them, then." Mermista made a valiant attempt to pretend she had dropped Catra from her attention and turned back to her homework.

"Well, see," said Catra, "I've got this piece of junk taking up space in my room. Glimmer mentioned Adora wanting it back." She flashed the trinket Glimmer had tried to reclaim from her—a golden pin shaped like a wing.

Mermista's eyes widened, clearly recognizing the pin, but immediately narrowed again in suspicion. "And you're just giving it back out of the goodness of your heart?"

Catra pressed a hand to her chest. "You don't think I have goodness in my heart?"

"I don't think you have a heart at all."

"Ask Adora what happened to it," Catra snapped, and turned to go. "Maybe I'll keep this thing after all."

Mermista groaned. "Ugh, you are so annoying. Fine, *please* give it back."

Catra turned around, now several steps away from enclave territory, and held up the pin. "You want it, come get it."

Mermista rolled her eyes, but seemed to find it reasonable that Catra didn't want to wade into her enclave group. She reluctantly left her seat and stepped closer, holding out her hand for the pin.

Catra laid the pin in Mermista's palm, slow and teasing—then flicked her hand away, claws leaving tiny slashes up Mermista's wrist. Mermista shouted and swung at her, but Catra danced out of her range, laughing, and disappeared into the stacks.

Mermista didn't pursue, too busy dealing with her entirely-negligible wound. Catra had no doubt the entire "princess alliance" would spend half the night examining those scratch marks for foul play, and the rest of it examining the wing pin

likewise. Catra hadn't done a thing to either of them; she hadn't needed to.

She got everything she needed the moment her bracelet came within six inches of the power-sharer on Mermista's wrist.

It was already working by the time Catra got back to her dorm. Mana from the Jakarta enclave's mana pool trickled hot and sweet through her veins, ready to do whatever she wanted it to do. *Too* hot and sweet, of course, carrying a whiff of the cloy of rot, but that was exactly what she needed. Even though she hadn't taken the life force of a living creature, this mana was still stolen, and thus close enough to malia that she could use it.

And it was *working*. The tiny thread of magic she'd spun, linking her anima to the tiger's-eye bracelet and the bracelet to Mermista's power-sharer, was siphoning power to Catra as smoothly as she could ever have dreamed. No one was stopping it, nothing was resisting it; no one knew the thread was there, or ever would, as long as she didn't get greedy.

Catra spent the next couple of hours casting every cleaning spell she knew, wiping away three years' residue of smoke, crumbs, old sweat, specks of blood, dirt and greasy dust of inexplicable origin. She hadn't even thought her room was very dirty. The process chased some kind of gauzy floating mal down from the ceiling, and burned up an egg sac she hadn't seen under her desk.

She cleaned her clothes and blankets, after that, cleaned everything she could see, until her room gleamed like the day she arrived. Like the day the induction spell sucked her through the void and dropped her in this room, a seasick freshman, terrified and hopeful and determined and so relieved to be here with Adora and away from their foster mother.

She had to sit down for a while, after the cleaning, tired out from effort and concentration. But she wasn't remotely out of mana. As

far as *that* sensation went, she couldn't even tell that she'd used any.

Was this how enclavers felt all the time? What Adora felt like all the time? Catra cradled her own malia-blackened arm, as if trying to comfort it, and hated the enclave princesses all the more.

She mended her clothes, then, all of the little rips and frays that usually weren't worth the bother, and one acid burn down the long glove that hid her blackened arm. Then put up half a dozen wards and shields around her room that she couldn't usually afford, especially not all at once.

She had warned herself against getting greedy, using too much too fast, but it felt impossible that anyone could ever notice what she took from this endless pool of mana. Surely she could afford to refill just one storage crystal. Maybe two.

She filled all of them, the sight of so many dark and empty crystals triggering a panic that went deeper than logic and patience and sense. She knew she'd gotten carried away. But it wasn't like she could undo it now, and nothing bad had happened—her thread of access remained unmolested. Uneasily, she decided not to worry about it.

She slept that night in a cocoon of shield magic, slept deep and unafraid for the first time in years. Maybe ever. In the morning, she headed off to the bathroom without bothering to negotiate an escort, shielded to the nines, feeling giddy and invincible.

She had just gotten undressed and turned the water on when everything went horribly wrong.

"Catra!"

The voice sounded garbled. The whole world was garbled, an uneven kaleidoscope of color and sound and encroaching darkness. She'd hit her head when she fell, probably, but that was

the least of her worries. Her whole body hurt indescribably, and she couldn't breathe, choking and gagging—

"Get her head out of the water or she'll drown."

"Is that blood? Where is it coming from?"

"I don't see any bite or claw marks, but not all mals—"

"Catra, can you hear me?" The first voice again—all the others had been different. This voice Catra knew down to her bones, so she didn't resist when its owner pulled her into their arms. Even though the motion made her hurt even more, made her gasp and choke, on her own blood this time.

A stranger's hand settled on Catra's chest, and she was too weak to flinch away. "Holy Goddess," said one of the other voices—maybe Perfuma? "She has blunt force trauma to her *whole body*. Internal bleeding, broken bones—it's like she got hit by a truck."

"Oh." That was Mermista. "Oh, shit."

"What?" demanded Adora. Catra had been trying not to realize it was Adora; too late. "Mermista, what do you know?"

Mermista's voice retained its lazy vocal-fry drawl. "I told you about that thing I found in my power-sharer, the siphoning spell. I cut it off."

"So?"

"So, the backlash on whoever cast it would be, like, intense. Like they'd been hit by a truck." Her tone grew defensive at whatever expression Adora was making. "What? She was stealing mana from my enclave, tons of it! I'm supposed to be sorry I stopped her?"

Adora made a frustrated sound, and turned her attention back to Catra, whose head had steadied a little—enough to feel that her ribs were broken, and her arms, and her pelvis. Enough to make

out Adora's face above her, in a fish-eyed, white-rimmed sort of way.

"It's all right, Catra," Adora said. "We're going to fix this."

"Adora, no." That was Glimmer; Catra caught a flash of pink in her peripheral vision.

"I'm not going to sit here and watch her die," Adora snapped.

"Look, I know you're scary-good at healing magic, but this kind of damage—you could pour mana into it all day and she'd still die—"

She could have saved her breath; Adora was already singing a healing spell.

Part of Catra wanted to shove her away, live or die on her own merits and never owe Adora a thing. Another part just wanted to live, whatever the cost. What actually won was the part that just wanted to stay here, in Adora's arms, watching her face while she sang and sang, with a little furrow of concentration between her brows and tears escaping from the corners of her eyes.

It was too bad the healing spell wasn't working.

Adora stopped, panting. "I need more mana."

Ah, so New York had cut Adora off from their mana pool before she could suck it dry. Pity.

Adora's friends were silent.

"I'll pay it back, I swear. I'll pay it back double. Mermista."

"No way." She had her back to the group, standing guard against mals. "I am not spending another drop of Jakarta's mana on a thieving maleficer."

"Glimmer!"

"Thieving maleficer, Adora. One who left *you* to die not that long ago."

More silence.

"I only have a little to spare," Perfuma said, kneeling beside Adora, "but I trust you to pay it back."

"Thank you," Adora said tearfully, taking her hand.

It wasn't enough, Catra could tell as soon as the song began again. Darkness was gathering around the edges of her vision.

"No, Catra, stay awake!"

"Glimmer," Perfuma said, "how much mana has Adora put into the New York pool? And how often does she ask for any of it back?"

Glimmer groaned and swore under her breath, but knelt and took Adora's hand in place of Perfuma. "I'm doing this for you, Adora, not *her*."

Adora just squeezed Glimmer's hand and took a deep breath. "I'm going to try a different spell." She started chanting, hard and fast, in Latin.

Catra's insides twisted, and she heard herself scream before she blacked out.

She woke with the last syllables of the healing spell still ringing in the air. She felt… raw, sore, exhausted. But her head was clear, and the soreness was nothing at all compared to the agony before.

"Catra?" Adora said softly, and Catra became suddenly, intensely aware that she was cradled in Adora's lap, sopping wet and stark naked. With something like a snarl, rough and breathless, she fought to her feet. Adora didn't try to stop her, may even have

tried to help her up. Catra stumbled to the bench where she'd left her things and pulled her towel around herself, clutching her clothes to her chest.

All Adora's enclaver friends—who must have taken a bathroom break while hanging out in Adora's room, just four doors down from Catra's—were staring at her. Catra barely noticed, unable to look away from Adora. She was still on the floor, legs splayed awkwardly, wet all over from Catra's body and drenched with her blood.

"You're okay now," Adora said, low and gentle, reassuring. She looked exhausted.

Catra barked a laugh without meaning to. She was so very far from okay.

"Why did you do that?" Catra hated that her voice shook, and rasped like she'd been screaming.

Adora frowned, as if confused. Her friends looked as if they might like to hear her answer, too. A few feet away, Catra realized, a trio of mals lay dead and smoking on the bathroom floor. Something, multiple somethings, had tried to attack while they were all distracted. Probably drawn by the smell of blood. Someone could have *died*.

"Why did you do it?" she demanded again. No one answered.

Keeping her back to the wall, Catra circled behind the enclavers—who turned to keep their eyes on her—and darted out the door.

Clumsily trying to get dry and dressed in her room, she caught sight of herself in the mirror. And stopped dead.

Her malia-blackened arm was healed.

Not entirely, judging by the lingering ache deep inside the flesh. But the skin was back to its normal, healthy color, and the joints moved easier. She could never have healed herself like this—malia couldn't repair its own damage, any more than fire could heal a burn. She hadn't thought *anyone* could heal it, except maybe some centuries-old guru on a mountaintop.

It would all come back, of course, when she continued using malia, because she literally couldn't stop now. But Adora had bought her time. More time to graduate, and find somewhere safe to settle, and work on repairing her anima before the damage killed her. Maybe.

Adora might be the reason she survived to adulthood. She was certainly the reason Catra had survived the last few hours, the reason she hadn't drowned in shower spray and her own blood on a bathroom floor. She *hated* that.

She kept remembering how it felt for Adora to hold her, frantic and pleading and completely focused on her. Even going against her shiny new friends for her. Catra could stay in that moment for a good long time.

And she hated that even more.

Chapter 4

Catra didn't bring it up, but after a few days Scorpia asked how the Big Plan was going, and she had to confess it had fallen through.

"It did get my arm healed, though. See?" She set down her chicken sandwich—underseasoned and disturbingly cold, but mal-free—and pulled off the long glove she'd continued to wear, out of habit and a desire not to have this conversation.

Scorpia gasped and prodded the arm with the tip of one pincer. "Wow! That's so great, wildcat!"

"Your neck is healed, too," Entrapta said, peering closely.

"My… neck?"

"Yeah, the black had spread onto your neck. Didn't you notice?"

"No." She'd stopped looking in mirrors. Catra cleared her throat. "Anyway. You both contributed to the project with the expectation of a payout, and I'm the only one who benefitted, so. Scorpia, you contributed a ton of mana, so you get the full contents of one crystal. Don't worry, it won't be malia because I'm giving it freely. Entrapta, as thanks for covering my homework while I worked out the spell, I'll give you that flower-growing incantation I had to write."

"Ooooh! I'm almost certain I can modify that to speed up the growth of my whole garden. Not that I'll have it much longer," Entrapta sighed. Graduation was in only a few weeks now.

"Oh, that reminds me," Scorpia said excitedly. "Entrapta's alliance voted me in! My name's on the wall and everything!"

"Glad to know they have some sense," Catra said, holding out a fist to bump against Scorpia's pincer. Something inside her

unclenched a little—Scorpia's chances of survival had just risen immeasurably.

"We ran our first obstacle course together yesterday," Scorpia continued. "It went really well!"

"Only one major injury, and I was able to mostly heal it," Entrapta agreed.

That *was* pretty good. The obstacle course, designed as practice for the Graduation Hall, could be very nearly as deadly as the real thing. Exactly as deadly, Catra supposed, if you were one of the inevitable handful of casualties. Most alliances would run the obstacle course multiple times a week for the six months before graduation.

"God, it's nuts, isn't it?" Catra said, almost to herself. "How much time and work goes into prepping for one dash across one room. The gates are only even *open* for half an hour."

Entrapta, focused on cutting her food into tiny cubes as per usual, hummed agreement. "From my research, I would say the Graduation Hall experience lasts ten minutes at most for any given student, assuming they make it out at all."

"Come with us, Catra," Scorpia said suddenly. "Graduate early."

Catra blinked. There was no rule against graduating early—who would enforce it if there was?—and there were always a few who tried. But that last year of education, planning, and increased mana capacity could make all the difference. "Why?"

"I just…" Scorpia cringed and scrubbed her pincers together. "I just hate to think of leaving you here alone."

"Alone? Hardly." Catra swept a hand out at the crowded cafeteria. "I'm surrounded by a thousand of my *closest friends*." Her glance snagged involuntarily on Adora and Glimmer on the other side of the room. Adora was laughing nearly to tears at something

Glimmer had said. Suddenly Glimmer cracked up, too; probably Adora had snorted like the dork she was.

Catra tore her eyes away. "Anyway, I'm not setting foot in that hall one second before I have to."

She had nightmares, sometimes, about graduation. About all her months and years of work and fear and suffering wasted, her throat ripped out by some hungry mal two steps into the Hall. Or worse—fighting her way through the swarm of mals against all odds and then, a moment away from freedom, getting snatched up by the mawmouth that guarded the gates. Horde Prime, they called it, because it was a whole horde of people crushed into one monstrous horror, Prime because it was the biggest one known to exist. Every year it got bigger by whatever number of students it caught, adding them to the maelstrom of churning organs, screaming mouths, and wild and weeping eyes that made up a mawmouth.

"Are you guys carrying anything as a failsafe against Horde Prime?" Catra asked.

Scorpia shuddered. Entrapta, quite calmly, said, "Yes, I'm building a little bomb, something with an intense but very small destruction radius. After all, I don't want to take anyone else with me. I suppose 'grenade' would be the word?" She patted Scorpia on the shoulder. "Don't worry, I'll toss it to you if you get caught and I don't." Scorpia bit her lip and nodded thanks.

The grenade, of course, was not to kill Horde Prime. Mawmouths couldn't be killed. The grenade was to kill Entrapta before the mawmouth could take her. If it got a single tendril around you, the fight was already over. Your only hope was to die quick.

"Anyway," Scorpia said, clearly desperate to change the subject, but Catra never got to hear the rest of the sentence. It was interrupted by music—clear, sweet, tinkly music, like windchimes, sad and beautiful and enchanting.

"Shit," Catra said, at the same time that someone else in the cafeteria screamed, *"Sirenspiders!"*

Looking up was stupid; she knew what she'd see, the time was better spent running for her life—but instinctively Catra looked up, and found the multilegged form of a bathtub-sized spider descending toward them at high speed. Screaming was even more useless than looking up, but she heard herself do it anyway.

The sirenspider halted suddenly, caught in a net of crackling red lightning.

"Come on!" Scorpia yelled, and Catra realized she was the one casting the net. She'd completely forgotten Scorpia's affinity for electricity.

Overhead, the sirenspider sizzled and blew apart. Entrapta excitedly grabbed a leg—sirenspider parts were very valuable to the right people—as they scrambled free of their lunch table and ran for the cafeteria doors.

They didn't make it very far before a table came tumbling end over end, propelled by someone's kinetic blast at a spider. It smashed straight into Entrapta with near-comical precision—except for the table leg that clipped Catra, throwing her in a different direction. She landed hard, in a tangle of overturned tables and chairs.

For a moment she lay stunned, and that nearly killed her, because it gave the siren-song a chance to work its way into her brain. Her eyes drifted closed, the music promising peace and rest and an end to fear…

All that saved her was Scorpia's voice yelling her name.

Catra jerked upright, stuffing her fingers in her ears, and spat the words to her Spanish fireball spell at the spider that had almost reached her foot.

The fireball didn't kill the spider—their shiny turquoise shells could protect them from the school's annual scouring with Mortal Flame, much less a panicked 17-year-old—but it made the thing retreat, scuttling off for easier prey. There was plenty of that to be had, and plenty had already *been* had; Catra could see half a dozen dead bodies from where she sat, drained bloodless and showing no sign of struggle.

"Catra!" Scorpia cried again, frantically scanning the room. Entrapta hung from her arms, dazed and bleeding. Neither of them saw her, Catra could tell, because Scorpia gave a frustrated whine, then turned and dashed for the doors.

Catra didn't blame her for leaving, of course. This was the Scholomance, where altruism got you killed in your first term. Scorpia was already carrying one wounded ally, which was as much as anyone could possibly expect from her.

But it did leave Catra in a bit of a spot.

Kicking and fighting her way through the furniture, she scrambled into the space between the wall and a table laying on its side. There was one kid there already, a scrawny black girl who didn't look old enough to be here. She barely glanced at Catra, too busy trying to stanch the flow of blood from some kind of gut wound, maybe from a spider's clawed leg.

Catra pressed her back to the table and put her fingers in her ears again. She could still hear the song, muffled and faint. She had a self-deafening spell, prepared for just such an occasion, but she'd never really used it once she was done testing it out, years ago. And the siren song kept distracting her. Part of her didn't actually want to stop hearing it, and that directly interfered with her ability to cast the spell.

The girl next to Catra hadn't been plugging her ears. She couldn't, not and deal with her stomach wound. Catra didn't notice when she gradually let her hands fall away and the bleeding resume.

But she noticed when the girl got to her feet and stepped out from behind the table.

"Hey! Hey, stop!" Catra wasn't going to risk anything for a stranger, but she could afford to yell, like Scorpia had yelled for her. She craned her head over her shoulder and around the edge of the table. "Get back here, you idiot!"

The girl didn't listen. She walked straight into the arms—limbs, anyway—of the nearest sirenspider.

Catra didn't watch what came next. She whipped her head back out of sight, closed her eyes, and cast the deafening spell almost faster than her lips could form the incantation. All sound vanished from her perception, her world suddenly silent as the grave.

She already had plenty of adrenaline in her system, but felt another dose hit her veins as she got to her feet. She was missing a sense now, no way to hear anything coming up behind her. She'd lost track of exactly where she was in the chaos—which way were the doors?

Shit, there was the girl with the stomach wound, collapsed on the floor—

Next to the sliced-up remains of the sirenspider. Adora, her sword shining through a thick layer of smoking black blood, was on one knee next to the girl, casting something that had her torn-up guts knitting back together. The girl didn't wake up, but she was breathing.

Catra must have made a noise; Adora looked up, eyes wide, and pushed to her feet. Catra couldn't hear her voice, but she knew Adora's face well enough to read the words. *"Catra! Oh, god, get out of here!"*

"You think?" Catra snapped, at what volume she didn't know, and bolted for the doors.

A dozen or more sirenspider corpses littered the cafeteria floor now, and probably even more had retreated into the air vents. But there were still plenty trying to converge on Catra as she sprinted across the cafeteria, vaulting over bodies and overturned furniture. Fireballs only helped with the spiders dropping from the ceiling with exposed underbellies. The others she hit with a quick-and-dirty version of the disintegration spell she'd once used to kill some scuttling thing inside a vending machine. It wasn't strong enough to vaporize a whole sirenspider, but half or even one-third of a sirenspider was just as good.

And there were the doors, she had a straight shot—

And there was Glimmer.

She was staring straight up at a descending spider, expression dreamy and peaceful. Judging from the piles of multi-legged bodies around her, she'd been fighting the spiders, trying to be a hero like Adora. But she wasn't as good as Adora, so one of them had gotten the drop on her. Or was doing so, right now.

A lot of things went through Catra's head in the space of a second. She could tell Adora's view of Glimmer was blocked by a serving counter, dragged far out of its place. Which meant Catra could be out the door in *two seconds* and no one would ever know she saw Glimmer at all. Trying to get to her would involve going back the wrong direction and fighting at least two more spiders. The disintegration spell took a lot of mana and the crystals around Catra's neck had all gone dark; she'd have to draw from her reserves to cast anything now. And Glimmer… Glimmer had wanted to let her die on a bathroom floor.

But she hadn't, because Adora had begged for Glimmer's help and she gave it, gave Adora the mana she needed to save Catra. What had she said to Adora? *'I'm doing this for you, not her.'* Perfectly valid, really, in the Scholomance.

And Glimmer had said something, just a few minutes ago, that made Adora laugh until she snorted. Adora would be devastated if

the stupid privileged frilly princess (that she'd left Catra for) got eaten by a spider.

Catra snarled aloud and turned back.

Three disintegrated sirenspiders later, she reached Glimmer just before her upraised hands, stretching toward her death like a toddler wanting uppies, could reach the spider. Still in the midst of leaping away from her third disintegration victim, Catra landed on her back and slid past Glimmer's feet, blasting a fireball straight up into the descending spider's underbelly. Charred bits of leg, shell and mandible rained around them.

Glimmer gasped, staggered, clutched her chest as her blank hypnotized eyes regained awareness. Then she looked wildly around, and her mouth fell open as she caught sight of Catra.

Catra fired off another disintegration without even looking at the spider she'd seen racing toward them in her peripheral vision. Glimmer jumped, then started talking—Catra was just as glad she couldn't hear her.

"For *her*, not for you," Catra said over whatever Glimmer was trying to say, and dashed out through the cafeteria doors.

Chapter 5

In the dream, Catra was soaked from head to toe, her hair dripping down onto Adora's chest. The gym floor was cold under Catra's knees, but her bare thighs were warm, straddling Adora's hips. Water from Catra's body was soaking through Adora's clothes, along with spots of blood, which was odd because Catra wasn't hurting anywhere. She felt like nothing could ever hurt her again. Except Adora. Adora would always be able to hurt her.

But Adora didn't seem disposed to hurt her now. She didn't look angry at Catra, or sad, or self-righteous, or exasperated—all the things Catra had gotten used to seeing since her world ended. Adora looked happy, hopeful, biting her lip as her hands slid up Catra's thighs.

She shouldn't be able to move, Catra thought vaguely. Didn't she remember this? Adora under her on the gym floor, paralyzed and helpless?

Well, she liked this better. And she especially liked that when Catra leaned down to kiss her, Adora surged up to meet her halfway.

Catra had wondered for years, *ached* for years, and now—now Adora's mouth was soft and hot and urgent on hers, tilting one way and then the other, as if bent on having her from every possible angle. Catra tangled desperate hands in her hair, kissed back hard until she had to break for air—then smeared more kisses across Adora's jaw, and dug teeth into the pulse point just under it. Gasping and shuddering, Adora held them both up with one arm, wrapping the other around Catra's naked back to pull her closer. *Adora wanted her closer. Adora wanted her.*

When Catra rocked forward, Adora's arm collapsed and they both dropped to the gym floor—but that was all right, the concrete was covered now with a cushion of flowing water, warm as a bath. She and Adora were wrapped around each other, hands and arms and

legs, their hair flowing together. Adora had every part of Catra gripped or cradled, and *god* it was the best Catra had ever felt in her life, like everything was finally all right, *she* was all right, she was warm and good and loved—

The school's breakfast bells jolted her out of the dream like a bucket of cold water.

Disoriented and gasping, Catra looked wildly around the room—her room, tiny and bare and empty, lit only by the faint glow of crystals full of malia. She fell back onto her pillow, then rolled over and screamed into it.

"Fuck!"

It certainly wasn't the first time Catra had dreamed about Adora, not even the first time she'd had a dream… like that, about Adora. But this had been much more vivid than ever before. It had felt so real, *still* felt so real. Losing it hurt worse than the spell backlash that had shattered her body.

Adora had kept trying to talk to her, after the sirenspider attack. Catra would have rather taken on a pack of leskets by herself, so she did whatever it took to avoid her, including skipping meals and even classes. After a few days, Adora seemed to realize her efforts were being counterproductive and backed off.

Adora's friends were not as smart.

After a few unsuccessful attempts, Glimmer and Bow finally cornered her in a stairwell—the same stairwell she had spied on Bow's door from, actually. Catra dashed up the stairs ahead of them, only to bounce off a shield of the same sort Adora had used to block the ends of the hall during her mindworm incident. With difficulty, Catra kept herself from tumbling backward down the stairs, and instead pressed herself against the wall where she couldn't be seen from below.

"We just want to talk, Catra," Glimmer called.

Catra growled. "Folks in hell want a drink of water."

"Adora wants—"

"Nope. I will literally put my self-deafening spell back on if you start talking about Adora."

Glimmer made a frustrated noise.

"We want to thank you," said Bow. "For saving Glimmer. *I* want to thank you."

"I didn't do it for you."

"And you didn't do it for me, either," said Glimmer. "But you did it. You risked your life—every extra second in that cafeteria was a risk to your life—to save someone you don't even like."

"Actively loathe, in fact."

"And it wasn't to serve your own purposes in any way. It was for Adora. Out of love for Adora."

"People are trying to *use* this stairwell, you know." They'd chosen a good time to corner her—right in the middle of breakfast, when most people were in the cafeteria, fighting through their spider-related PTSD to get to the bacon and eggs—but she could hear footsteps approaching from above.

"We'll let you go, then," Glimmer said airily, like some high-class lady signing off on a phone call. "But you've tipped your hand. Now Adora knows there's still good in you, Darth Catra, and so do we. Expect us to act accordingly."

The shield winked out. Catra darted up the stairs, but took the time to fling a cute little stinkbomb spell down behind her. She heard it go off with a puff, followed by gagging and retching.

"I still know you have good in you," Glimmer shouted up the stairwell, in between coughs, "even though you're a *bitch!*"

Catra laughed blackly and slammed the next level's door behind her.

Catra thought it was a little pretentious that alchemy, the least popular of the Scholomance's three academic tracks, wasn't just called "potions." It was the art of pressing magic into substances, usually liquids, the same way artifice was the art of pressing it into objects and devices. A good potion (or balm, or gel, or whatever) could be a *fantastic* tool, and cost no mana to use, because the necessary mana had already gone into making it. But a disproportionately small number of students went alchemy track; the medium had major limits, and was almost as hard as artifice without as much payoff.

Plus, though a botched artifice might blow up in your face, at least it wouldn't *flood the school with acid* the way some goddamn idiot alchemist had just done.

Well, not the *whole* school, Catra assumed; the hissing hot-pink liquid didn't seem to be eating through the metal floor, just the towels and shower curtains. It was just her luck that the alchemy lab was on the same floor as the junior dorms.

Catra and Lonnie, standing guard for each other while they showered, had both started shouting and swearing when someone threw the bathroom door open—letting in an ankle-deep wave of acid.

The door opener shouted over them. "We need access to the drains! Get out before it spreads!" Then she was gone, probably to open the boys' bathroom down the hall.

Pink acid already filled the doorway, fanning out in all directions; getting out before it spread wasn't on the table. Catra scrambled up on a toilet, snarling and lashing her tail. Lonnie shouted an incantation—something in Latin about walking on water—and her feet rose on the wave of acid as it reached them. She bobbled a bit, but stayed on top of the liquid.

"It probably won't get as high as you," Lonnie called over her shoulder at Catra, and legged it.

Catra, back pressed to the wall as her feet tried to slip off the toilet seat, watched the acid level rise even as it started glugging down the drains. *Two near-death experiences in one bathroom is enough,* she decided. *If I make it out of this alive, I'm peeing in a pot and tossing it into the void from now on. And forgoing showers altogether.*

What did she have that could counter acid? Her purification spell was much too small and too expensive. She didn't have any spells that altered pH. She had a shield spell that was probably strong enough to keep it out, but it wasn't designed to go all the way to the floor, maybe she could—

Some kind of mal tried to struggle up through the drain, and failed, dissolving before her eyes. Any dead mal was a win for the students, but Catra still shuddered at the sight.

Even that slight movement made her slip on the toilet seat; she had to dig her claws into the wall to keep from falling off. At least she wasn't wet from the shower, having let Lonnie go first, though she supposed she could have dried off—

Wait. That might work.

She took a deep breath and started pulling together her quick-drying spell, a handy little thing she'd recently found in a collection of health-and-hygiene charms. It was even in English.

Will away, will away,
Rain and bath and drink and spray,
Liquid I don't want to stay,
Will away, will away.

It was a little hard to focus through the shouts and screams that echoed down the hall as the acid spread. Ominously, there was no sound at all coming from upstream.

She made a change to the second line—*Rain and acid, drink and spray*—and experimentally dropped her tail toward the steaming pink liquid. The acid retreated from the tip of her tail, as if she were encased in a thick, invisible shell. For a moment, anyway; then it started closing in. The spell was designed to be a one-and-done cast. She'd have to keep it going the whole time she was in the acid.

Which had almost reached the lid of the toilet, even with the drains sucking it down as fast as they could.

Another deep breath, and Catra slid off the seat, keeping up a constant stream of mana and a chant of *Will away, will away*. Sure enough, the invisible shell kept the acid away from her. She walked toward the bathroom door on perfectly dry tile, like a chimeric Moses, moving as fast as she could without losing concentration. How long would it take to get to the end of this deadly lake?

When she reached the hallway, she saw why the acid level in the bathroom was rising so fast; a net-like shield covered the hallway just past the boys' bathroom, holding back the acid, which was still gushing out of the alchemy lab far behind her. Catra barely had time for a jolt of panic—*trapped!*—before a voice called out to her.

"Don't worry, it lets anything with a heartbeat come through!" Bow was balanced on a metal chair, arrows at the ready and a long, wicked knife on his hip. "Including some mals, so I'm stationed here to intercept."

Just a do-gooder, out here doing good. Catra rolled her eyes and stepped through the shield, feeling it drag against her skin like a cobweb as it let her through.

The level of acid out here was considerably lower, but she didn't want her feet burned off any more than her knees. *Will away, will away…*

"We're telling everyone to evacuate *up*," Bow said. "The acid's going to keep spreading until the drains catch up, and it's reached the stairwells now, so—"

"Got it." Like anyone would go *down* to escape danger anyway—maleficaria almost always got in from the bottom of the school and worked their way up.

Catra passed the door to her own room on the way to the stairs, and winced to think of the damage her belongings were taking even now. Panic fluttered at the idea of having no desk, no bed, no clothing—but she couldn't afford to think about it now. She'd lose control of the spell keeping the acid off her feet.

Bow wasn't kidding about the stairwell. Catra could already hear liquid splashing before she opened the door, releasing a fresh wave into the hot-pink waterfall pouring down the steps. Sucked to be a senior today. Catra hoped Scorpia and Entrapta were all right.

She was finally able to release the liquid-repellant spell as she turned up the stairs. She'd made it five or six steps before she heard voices and clattering, coming up behind her.

"We're almost there, come on!"

Shit. That was Adora's voice.

"I *can't…"* replied a breathless whine.

"Yes, you can!"

"Just a little further, Jingye!"

The little group came around the turn of the stairs, finally out of the flow of acid, and staggered to an exhausted halt. Two Russian seniors Catra half-recognized released each other's hands, along with the levitation spell that had kept them just an inch above the acid. Jingye, presumably, was the Asian boy half-collapsed in Adora's arms, covered in horrifying acid burns.

Catra stepped to one side so the Russians could dash past her, then folded her arms and glared down at the other two. "Hey, Adora."

Adora's gaze snapped up to Catra's face, her expression a peculiar mix of wariness, relief and hope. "Catra!"

"Last I checked, you couldn't kill an alchemy experiment with a sword," Catra said, "so what the hell are you doing?"

"There's still people down there, I need to—"

"You need to what, exactly? This is way outside your wheelhouse, Adora! Stop playing hero in circumstances you're no better suited for than the people you're 'rescuing'! How are you even keeping that acid from melting you into goo?"

"Oh, these boots are enchanted," Adora said excitedly, picking up one foot to waggle at her. "They're basically indestructible. So as long as I don't wade any deeper than the boots—"

"You're an *idiot*. Or haven't you noticed all the little pinprick burns on your legs where you've splashed yourself walking?"

"That doesn't matter right now." Adora sounded exasperated.

Somewhere below, a voice started crying for help.

"I have to go!" Adora hauled Jingye up a few stairs—and shoved him into Catra's arms.

"What—"

"Take him somewhere safe, try to get him to his friends."

"I am *not* taking him—"

"Yes, you are," Adora said, smiling serenely, and leaned closer to —Catra's brain stuttered to a halt—to press a kiss to Catra's forehead.

Then Adora dashed back down the stairs, leaving Catra with a moaning and wheezing senior in her arms that she absolutely *could* just drop right here in the stairwell.

Something with eyes shifted behind a seam in the wall.

"Come on," Catra snapped, and hauled Jingye up the stairs.

The language halls were on the next level. Catra stuffed Jingye into a language learning booth, where a white soundproofed cocoon closed over them, the better to listen and practice without disturbing others. It meant you couldn't hear anything creeping up behind you, but it also gave some privacy and the basic protection of not sitting injured in the open. It was an extremely tight fit for two people, though; Jingye fell into the chair, while Catra crawled onto the desk.

"All right, kid, how close are you to kicking the bucket?" Catra said.

"I'm a year older than you, *kid*," Jingye wheezed in Mandarin-accented English. "And I will be fine, I have… medical supplies…" Weak and clumsy, he rummaged through the inside pockets of his vest, where bottles clinked. More gleamed through the long stripes of acid damage in his clothes.

Catra flipped his vest open and shoved the vial he was fumbling for into his hand. He bit off the top—okay, um, single-use edible vials were apparently a thing—and gulped down the cloudy-gray contents. Immediately his breathing steadied, his hands stopped shaking, and he regained a little color and strength.

"Well, that looked useful," Catra said, feeling her voice go silky in a way that would have put anyone less distracted on high guard. She cleared her throat. "Did you make that yourself?"

"Family recipe. Just steadies the vitals for a bit, long enough to get help."

"So you're alchemy track." Jingye nodded. "You the one who started this shit?"

He snorted, now rummaging for something else. "I'm a *competent* alchemist, thanks. Ah." He pulled out a squeezable tube and began smearing its contents—some kind of ointment—onto his acid burns.

"What else have you got that's medical?" Catra asked, carefully neutral.

"Uh, fever reducer, a couple antivenins, hydration salts, pain reliever—" Belatedly, he gave her a suspicious look. "Why?"

"Maybe Adora's willing to work for free. I'm not." She held out a hand, claws opening around her palm like a flower. "Hand 'em over."

Jingye looked at the claws, the tail, the fangs. "Shit. You're that maleficer, the chimeric."

"Yep. You wanna give me mana instead? It doesn't look like you have it to spare."

Jingye groaned—growled, almost—and stopped smearing ointment long enough to select a few more vials from inside his ruined vest. "Fever reducer. Two antivenins. Hydration salts. Pain reliever."

The labels were in Chinese; she'd want to get an independent translation. Whatever they were, they were sure to be valuable. She tucked the vials inside her shirt, the handy little place anyone with breasts could store a few things.

"Thanks for your help." Jingye's voice was barbed. "I've got it from here."

"I bet you do," Catra said, grinning, and left him there.

As she headed down the aisle of cocoon-shrouded language booths toward the door, Catra rubbed the spot on her forehead that hadn't stopped feeling Adora's lips like a brand all this time. Adora would be horrified at what she'd just done, all but mugging an injured innocent she'd entrusted Catra with.

Good.

By dinner time, the acid was down the drains and off into the void. It burned out quite a number of mals in the end, which was good for everyone, and only killed two students, which was only bad for them.

What *was* bad for Catra was the damage to her belongings. Her desk had miraculously managed to lose three inches of height *without* toppling over and dumping her homework and supplies; she got the legs restored with make-and-mend and some scrap wood. The bed she didn't bother repairing, just hacked off the damaged legs (thus the scrap wood) and let it rest on the floor. The bed *had* tipped, unfortunately, and now she had no blanket or pillow and only half a mattress. The mattress would do for tonight, Catra decided, if she could borrow a blanket from Scorpia, who tended to be cold and had cadged extra blankets from somewhere. Scorpia and Entrapta, she'd been relieved to discover, had been on a trip to the stockrooms together when the flood happened; they didn't even know about it until it was over.

According to Entrapta, who kept track of such things for some esoteric reason, neither of the students who died had been Chinese. So Jingye made it. Not that Catra cared, but it was good to know where she might find useful potions in the future.

During dinner, Catra spotted Adora at a closer table than usual, participating in some kind of circle spell where everyone at the table held hands and chanted. Catra accidentally caught her eye as she looked up at the end of the chant. Adora smiled tentatively. Catra looked away.

"All right, Adora, we need to talk," Catra said to her mirror, feeling like an idiot—but she needed to know exactly what she was going to say. "We need to talk about this idea you seem to have that you and I are okay again, or friends, or *something*. We are not okay. We are not friends. We are not… something." She growled and rubbed her forehead.

"I mean, sure, you were my entire world for most of my life," she muttered, more to herself now than any imaginary Adora, "but whatever, stuff happens. People go down different paths. Your path led to you being some kind of enclave princess hero knight, which is all your dreams coming true—without me—and I'm about as far from that path as it's possible to be—without you—which is. My nightmares coming true." She tore her claws through her hair. "*Point being*, I have not remotely forgiven you for leaving me, or for emptying my crystals and forcing me into malia use—then acting like *I* was the problem! If… if you're ready to apologize, I might be ready to hear it. I dunno.

"But either way, you do not get to lean on me for your do-gooding. I am not a member of your Princess Alliance or Get Ourselves Killed Club or whatever—someone said Best Friends Squad but I refuse to believe that one. I don't have the luxury of spending resources on strangers when it's all I can do to keep myself alive. And that's *your fault*. So don't act like *I'm the problem*. And don't you dare ask anything of me unless you're willing to… come home." A nonsensical way to put it. This wasn't home, and God knew neither of them had left it. But she couldn't think of any other phrasing that fit.

And what if Adora did "come home"? Things could never go back to how they were. They could never be what they used to be. But maybe they could be *something*. Maybe.

God, it was dangerous to even let herself think that way. Maleficers didn't get to hope for things.

Well, if she was going to talk to Adora tonight, she had to do it now, before curfew put everyone into lockdown for the night.

No one answered her knock at Adora's dorm, so Catra headed for the place everyone tended to gather if they didn't specifically need to be elsewhere—the library.

Sure enough, Catra spotted a familiar blond ponytail as soon as she came through the doors. Silently she ducked behind the first row of shelves, and looked out between books as she paced the perimeter of the reading room. Two-thirds of her mind was, of course, watching for anything that might jump out of the shadows; the rest was debating how to draw Adora away from her fawning admirers. Adora's friends would not like her disappearing into the stacks with a maleficer, but Catra wanted some modicum of privacy for—

Between one step and the next, Catra stopped dead. She'd finally gotten a full, clear look at Adora, and she wasn't studying or scribbling out an essay, or even practicing a spell. She was sitting across a table from a brawny senior girl, arm wrestling.

This in itself was no cause for the hot-cold-hot sensation suddenly twisting Catra's insides. Adora liked showing off her muscles in much the same way Catra liked showing off her agility and speed; that was nothing new. It was Adora's expression that stopped her in her tracks.

Starry-eyed. That was the only word for it. Adora was smiling at the senior girl like she hung the moon, trying desperately to look cool and, as usual, only managing a stupidly endearing half-awkward, half-justified cockiness. She bit her lip as her hand heaved against the other girl's, both their arms bulging and trembling with strain.

"Come on, Adora, you can do it!" Sparkles called out, with Bow and a few others echoing the sentiment.

Others chanted in favor of her opponent, pumping their arms. "Hun-ta-ra! Hun-ta-ra!"

The other girl—Huntara, apparently—had probably twenty pounds of muscle and a foot in height on Adora. With slow inevitability, she bore Adora's arm down to the table. Competing cries of triumph and disappointment filled the air. Adora took the loss with good grace, smiling even as she rubbed her arm muscles and groaned. Flushed and out of breath, she looked up at Huntara through her lashes as if suddenly shy.

Catra grabbed onto the bookshelf, swimmy-headed and nauseous.

"You put up a good fight, pup," said Huntara, offering a handshake. Adora turned the handshake into a back-slapping hug.

"Yeah, y-you too," Adora said. "I mean, obviously. Since you beat me. Um. Rematch?"

Huntara laughed, looking down at Adora like she was, well, adorable. Which she was, but Huntara had no right to look at her like that. "Not this close to curfew. Maybe tomorrow."

"Oh, curfew…" Adora glanced at her watch and winced.

"Come on, Adora, I want to hit the snack machines before bed," Glimmer said, tugging her away.

"Right, right." Adora looked over her shoulder at Huntara, eyes still sparkling. "Tomorrow, then, Huntara! I'm holding you to it!"

She and Glimmer were walking right toward Catra's hiding spot—but Catra wasn't there when they reached it. She was out the library doors and racing down the stairs to the senior level.

The first curfew warning bell rang just as Catra pounded on Scorpia's door.

Scorpia opened it with her stinger at the ready. Her eyes widened at the sight of Catra. "Wildcat? What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Catra was surprised to hear how raspy and choked her voice sounded. Her hand shook as she pushed her hair out of her

eyes. "Nothing's wrong. I've just changed my mind."

"About what?"

"I want to graduate early."

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> NOTE: I am not even half doing justice to the canon version of fixing the Graduation Hall machinery, which took dozens of people and months of prep. Here, I am making it serve the purposes of the story I want to write. Naomi Novik, forgive me.

Scorpia and Entrapta's graduation allies didn't want Catra.

Catra hadn't *really* expected any differently. They already had four people, which was kind of the sweet spot for alliance sizes, and graduation was in less than two weeks. There wasn't time to properly add a new person to their plan and get sufficient practice with them.

Plus, she was a maleficer. You couldn't trust a maleficer. No one said it out loud, but she could hear it nonetheless.

"Absolutely not," she said when Scorpia made noises about herself and Entrapta withdrawing to ally with Catra instead. "You have a good group and a good plan. Shaking things up now is only going to get all of us killed. I'll find someone else."

"I could ask Tom," Scorpia offered. "I think there's only three people in his group."

"Tom?"

"The, um, surviving member of my old alliance."

"Sure, worth a shot."

Tom's group didn't want her, either, and this time they made *sure* she knew it was because she was a maleficer.

"We can't have someone at our backs," said Tom, "that might suck us dry to save herself at any moment."

"Technically," Catra pointed out, "anyone could, with the right spell."

One of Tom's teammates bared her teeth. "But you're the one with a long and storied history of stealing mana."

Oh, that's why the girl looked familiar. Catra had yanked some mana from her several months before, without blurring her memory because they were interrupted. Yeah, she wasn't sure she wanted that hostility at *her* back either.

Well, whatever. Other alliances would be interested in her *because* she was a maleficer. It meant she'd have plenty of power to contribute to the cause, and, according to the old wives' tales, she'd have the school's favor and the maleficaria's disfavor. She'd find something. And if she didn't, she'd just wait until next year after all.

But she knew she wasn't going to wait. Every time she glanced across the library, the cafeteria, a classroom—even the hallway outside her own room—and saw a blonde ponytail, she decided all over again that she'd rather fight the entire graduation horde herself than stay here another year.

One week before graduation, Adora climbed on top of a table in the cafeteria and cleared her throat.

A startled silence fell, inasmuch as a room with that many people could ever be silent. Everyone knew who Adora was. Everyone wanted to hear what she had to say.

To Catra's eyes, Adora looked a little unnerved by the sudden rapt attention, but she only cleared her throat again and spoke. "Every year we lose roughly half the senior class to the graduation horde. We were never meant to have to fight our way out of the school. The only reason it's like this is the broken cleansing machinery."

So far, so obvious. The whole school was swept by curtains of Mortal Flame at the end of each term, scouring out as many mals as possible; that was supposed to apply to the Graduation Hall as well, except that the mals themselves had broken the relevant machinery over a century ago. Every student knew that coming in.

"People I care about are going into that hall this year," Adora continued. "I want them to come out the other side. I want them to make it home. I want *everyone* to make it home, and I wish I could promise that. But I can at least give you a better than fifty percent chance." She took a deep breath. "I'm going to fix the cleansing machinery in the Graduation Hall."

Instant bedlam. Some kids were cheering, some were shouting questions, some were laughing in bitter disbelief.

Catra sat silent, her entire brain ground to a halt.

"Like *that's* never been tried before," muttered a girl sharing Catra's table. Because it *had* been tried before, multiple times, by teams of full-grown experts who were mostly never seen again.

"Adora, that's a suicide mission!" Glimmer, pulling on Adora's shirt hem, was not as quiet as she probably thought she was. "What are you *thinking?* Get down from there!"

Arrow Boy was just as appalled. "You don't even know *how* to fix those machines!"

"I'm an artificer, I'll figure it out."

"You specialize in weaponry, not—"

"Listen, pup, this is not necessary." That was Huntara, fucking Huntara, the whole reason Adora was even thinking about this, the 'person she cared about' that was worth a suicide mission. "Us seniors can take care of ourselves. We'll be fine."

Adora just looked down at her friends with her eyes narrowed and her jaw set. Catra knew that look. Nobody was going to talk Adora

out of this, not with all the argument or logic or outright begging in the world. She had decided this was the right thing to do, and nothing could stop Adora once she decided on the right thing to do.

Catra closed her eyes, her body cold all over, her mind filling with images of Adora—surrounded, overwhelmed, ripped apart by too many mouths and claws and hideous eldritch appendages to count. She could take a lot of mals with her, for sure, but no one could take on every mal in the Hall. All to save a bunch of strangers, and fucking *Huntara*.

And, in fairness, also to feed her goddamn hero complex, which pre-dated the Scholomance by several years. And which had mostly developed by continually rescuing Catra—punching school bullies, lying to their foster mother, climbing trees to coax Catra down when she got stuck. Adora had a very ugly scar on one shoulder from freshman year, when a nightfang took a chunk out of her—because she tackled Catra away from it.

They had promised to always look after each other. Instead, Adora had left Catra behind, helpless, forced into vice and villainy just to survive. She'd broken their promise.

But Catra hadn't. And Catra wouldn't.

She stood up and started walking.

Bow, it seemed, had given up on arguing and gone silently grim. Glimmer had not.

"You think you're going to repair a complicated and unfamiliar artifice while also fighting off a horde of maleficaria?"

"Pffft, you know I can fight a pack of mals with one hand behind my back."

"While using that hand to repair machinery? Adora, no matter how good you are, there is only one of you! You will never survive going in there alone!"

"She's not going alone."

Glimmer and Bow turned slowly and gaped at her, wide-eyed. Along with a bunch of their other friends, and everyone at the surrounding tables. Catra pinned her ears back, but didn't retreat. Instead she climbed up on the table with Adora.

Adora was staring at her too, not so much shocked as horrified. "No! Absolutely not!"

"I don't care whether you *want* my help, Adora. I'm going to be dropping into that hall, too—yes, I'm graduating early—so I have a vested interest in making sure your plan actually works." She turned around, sweeping her gaze over the crowd. "WE ALL DO," she shouted, angry and accusatory. "Every one of you is going into the Graduation Hall sooner or later, if you're lucky. If we can fix the cleansing machinery, it's not just this year's graduates who will benefit."

"The mals will have it broken again by the time I'm a senior," shouted a younger kid.

"Yeah, maybe," Catra said. "But there won't be *very* many mals left to try, now will there?"

"If we keep fixing it every year," Adora said excitedly, "maybe even every term, before very many mals can congregate, we may never have a proper Graduation Horde again!"

Catra wanted to smash her own face into a wall—or Adora's face, she wasn't picky. In the unlikely event that Adora survived this foray into the underworld, she was just going to do it again next year?

One disaster at a time, Catra told herself.

The tone of the cafeteria was at least cautiously hopeful now, which was about as good as the Scholomance got. Kids were chanting Adora's name, talking excitedly to their friends—one or

two were in tears, letting themselves hope for maybe the first time in years.

"Right," Catra snapped, cutting through the noise. "So this needs to be an actual plan, not a one—or two—person suicide mission. We'll need proper artificers, to start with."

Bow, still looking grim, raised his hand.

Glimmer gasped. "Bow, no!"

"Ooh, ooh, me! Me, I want to go!" Entrapta cried, climbing onto her table and waving her arms. Next to her, Scorpia's eyes were very wide. Catra hadn't even realized the two of them were in the room.

Seconds ticked by. No one else volunteered.

Catra heard Glimmer take a deep, trembling breath. Then she climbed onto the table beside Catra and Adora.

"The next volunteer," she shouted, loud enough to make Catra's ears ring, "gets a spot in New York Enclave."

That changed the game *entirely*.

Within the next five minutes, six enclaves were offering spots and they had four more artificers.

"Glimmer," Adora whispered urgently. "Glimmer, you don't have another spot to offer—"

"She has her own," Bow said somberly.

"What—"

"I won’t need it," Glimmer said serenely. "Any enclave would fall all over themselves to bring in someone who helped fix the cleansing machines. But yeah, if I have to give them my spot, I will. WE'LL NEED GOOD FIGHTERS, TOO." The return to shouting

was sudden enough to make Catra jump. "GOOD SHIELDS, EVEN MORE SO. YOU, ON THE LEFT—"

Recruitment proceeded apace. Whatever Adora and Catra had started, it was snowballing beyond what they'd imagined.

And the project was in good enough hands with Sparkletits, Catra decided. She could feel the eyes of the whole cafeteria on her—Adora's eyes on her, Adora's arm brushing hers with every breath—and she needed to be anywhere but here. No point standing up like a painted target, after all. If she was waiting to be offered an enclave spot, she'd clearly be waiting forever.

She caught Glimmer's eye and gave her a jerky nod, just to confirm that she was still on board. Then she climbed down from the table and slipped away toward the doors.

"Catra!"

Adora's voice stopped her in her tracks, as always, however much she hated herself for it. Ears pinned, she looked back over her shoulder.

Adora's expression was complicated; big sad eyes, tight angry mouth, something in the eyebrows that was both pleading and betrayed.

Yeah, well, Catra wasn't a bit sorry she'd spoiled Adora's one-woman hero show. She hissed under her breath, tail lashing, and continued out the door.

Back in her dorm, Catra very, very calmly finished her homework, took a sponge bath after purifying some kind of malicious dust out of the water, and ate the snack-machine peppermint candy she'd been saving as a treat. She crawled into bed and turned out the mana-lamp.

After a moment, she growled under her breath and turned the lamp on again. She could ignore the pain when she was awake,

but it was hard to sleep through it. She was going to wade into the Graduation Horde in a few days, and she probably wasn't going to survive, but sleep deprivation sure wouldn't help her odds.

Or Adora's.

She retrieved Jingye's pain-relief salve from the bedside table and rubbed it into the tips of her fingers, which had started to darken again, as if she'd touched a flame and gotten burned.

"What," Mermista snapped, "are you doing here? Glimmer, what is *she* doing here?"

Ah, yes. Mermista hadn't been in the cafeteria the day before; she didn't know how things had gone down. In a spirit of generosity, Catra only folded her arms and glared poisonously at the Indonesian girl, instead of slashing her claws across her face.

The planning meeting for the machinery mission was taking place —of course—in the New York Enclave's staked-out area of the library. Considerately, they were starting in the latter half of the lunch period, so that no one missed class and people had time to eat beforehand. Catra had bolted down half a lunch, shoved the rest into her pockets, and nearly choked to death on a wilted spring roll in the stairwell.

And now this piece-of-nothing enclaver didn't want to let her through the circle of velvet ropes someone had magicked into being around New York's tables. Inside the circle—along with the obvious Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta—were a number of kids Catra didn't know, and a few that she did. Perfuma, of course, and little Frosta—no way were they taking a *freshman* along, screw that noise—and some idiot artificer she only recognized because of how often he'd set fire to the workshop. Then Scorpia—shit, when had that happened? After Catra had left the cafeteria, clearly. And a fellow chimeric and low-key maleficer, Double

Trouble, who had to be the last person Catra would have expected to risk their skin.

And Adora, of course, bent over a sheet of blueprints at the next table, deep in conversation with some of the artificers who'd volunteered in return for enclave spots.

Glimmer finally turned to see what her friend was on about. "She's on the team, Mermista."

"The hell she is."

"The hell I'm not," Catra said. Her gaze was still over Mermista's shoulder at Adora. She looked good—determined, confident, purposeful. She had new clothes, clean and whole; the red jacket tickled Catra's senses, even from here, with some kind of warding or shield that Adora would *clearly* need.

"Speaking of hell," Mermista made a complicated gesture that smelled of warding, like Adora's jacket, "have we forgotten Catra's an evil, blackhearted killer?"

Catra returned her attention to Mermista, baring her teeth. "And yet here you are, pissing me off."

Adora left her blueprints and approached the growing commotion. Catra watched her expression change when her eyes met Catra's, all that glowing purpose fading into worry.

"Mermista," Adora said. "Catra's on the team."

"In fact, she *started* the team," Glimmer said.

Mermista snorted. "Pretty sure Adora did that."

"I started the *project*." With softer eyes than Catra had seen since the day Adora joined an enclave, she continued, "Catra was the first to stand up beside me."

Glimmer winced, perhaps recalling that she herself was, in fact, the *fourth* to stand up beside her supposed bestie.

"Well, that's awesome." Sarcasm dripped off Mermista's words like acid. "But this is the last project we need muddied up with malia, I think."

"Fortunately I don't care what you think," Catra said. "And if you're so determined to keep malia out of it, you should know there's already two maleficers on the team, and no, I'm not going to tell you who." Entrapta was fairly open about it if anyone asked, but if Catra outed Double Trouble, they'd *all* regret it.

Perfuma put a hand on Mermista's shoulder. "Mista, this might be a wonderful opportunity for Catra to restore balance. By taking the mana she got by harming others, and using it to *help* others, she can—"

Mermista shoved her away. "This mission isn't about helping *Catra* improve herself!"

"It's not about your grudge about the mana pool either," Adora snapped.

"It's about saving people's lives," said Frosta. "You know, the opposite of what maleficers tend to do."

Catra pointed at Frosta with recoiling fingers, like she was mold on bread. "Why is that thing talking? Isn't that a freshman? What are you even going to do, use her for bait?"

"Meet the *bait* in the gym and I'll show you what use I can be!"

Catra laughed. "Because that went well for you last time. I could kill you and not even notice, snowcrab."

They were drawing attention, voices rising all around. Glimmer tried to call for quiet, but Bow was pulling her aside, murmuring urgently in her ear.

The arsonist artificer shouldered in front of Frosta, puffed up his chest and said, "I think you should be picking on someone your own size, madam."

"What, like you? You wouldn't even be *worth* harvesting for mana."

"You see?" Mermista cried. "That's where her mind immediately goes, and you want *her* at our backs?"

Adora looked incensed. "That's not—"

"Hey now," Scorpia shouted over her, "Catra is a loyal and dependable friend—"

"And a very powerful wizard," Entrapta added brightly.

Mermista tapped her chin faux-thoughtfully. "Does it count as 'powerful' when all the power is stolen?"

"Not just stolen." That was a girl Catra dimly recognized as a friend of Glimmer's, a senior with dark skin and white hair. Netossa? "Built from death and suffering. It's closer to murder than theft, even when the victim survives."

"Oh, what kind of sense does that make?" Catra demanded.

"You'd understand if you'd ever had it done to you."

"And what it does to the maleficer is almost as bad," said Netossa's girlfriend, Spinny something. "It rots your soul even more than your body."

"Which is why no spell you cast can be trusted," said Huntara, fucking Huntara, because the universe was *trying* to push Catra to her limit. "Intention matters more than anything in magic, and when your intentions aren't pure—"

"Pure!" The word burst from Catra as more than half a snarl, and the ones that followed weren't much better. "When your stupid

plan fails and you all die, I'm sure every senior class that gets torn apart afterward will care so much that the mission stayed *pure!"*

It was a testament to her natural powers of intimidation, Catra supposed, that just by raising her voice, she could make half the room act like she'd lunged at them with a sword. Suddenly the air was thick with spells kept in waiting and the smell of adrenaline.

Adora's voice was incongruously bright and chirpy. "Catra, we should talk." She grabbed Catra's arm and pulled her—none too gently—out of the crowd and away into the stacks.

One did not simply march off into the stacks, where shelves loomed all the way up into the void, pages rustled with no hand touching them, and any kid who fell asleep at a desk woke up somewhere they'd never seen before, if they were lucky enough to wake at all.

But Adora, of course, rushed in where angels feared to tread. And when she reached a solid wall—the back of a study carrel—she didn't stop to see if anyone or anything were inside it, just shoved Catra against the wood with rough hands on her shoulders.

"Ow, Adora, what the hell—"

"Why are you *doing* this?"

Catra shoved her back, though she didn't go very far—good God, she'd grown even more muscular this term. "It's not my fault your friends want to pick a fight about malia!"

"Not *that*. Why are you insisting on coming along?"

Catra blinked. "What?"

"The whole point of all this was for you *not* to go down there until it's safe!"

"You are not making sense. I know you're trying to make it safe for the graduates, but you have half a dozen of them on the team —"

"I don't mean the graduates. I mean *you."*

Catra went silent in utter bafflement. God help her, it was hard to think at all with Adora this close. She had her hands on Catra's shoulders again, not shoving this time but cupping them gently. "I don't know what you're talking about, Adora," she said, peevish and almost plaintive.

"I *already knew* you were looking for a graduation alliance, Catra. Leaving early. And I couldn't stand to *think* about you down there…"

"Not to mention Huntara, right?" Catra said bitterly.

"Huntara…? I mean, sure, I want her to make it, too. Like I said before, I want everyone to make it. And I admit, the chances are a lot better with a team, and I did make the announcement hoping some people would be willing to help. But even if they weren't…"

"You were going to go alone. Because you're an idiot."

A sheepish smile briefly lit her face. "Yeah, maybe. But I'm not alone now, we have plenty of people on the team. So you can bow out. Please."

"Bow out?" Catra knocked Adora's distracting hands away. "What, am I an *embarrassment* to you? You're afraid to be seen 'consorting' with a maleficer? Are you one of the idiots who would rather die than let me use my evil blackhearted malia to help you?"

"No!"

"And will any of those 'plenty of people' on the team be looking out for *you?* Watching your back?"

Adora laughed. "Nobody *needs* to—"

"Right. So you might as well *still* be going alone. Except you're not, because I'm going with you. Not with the team. With *you."* She stabbed a finger into Adora's chest.

Adora just stood there, looking stunned, while Catra paused to catch her breath. In a quieter voice, Catra continued, "You know if you died down there, I wouldn't even know for sure until next year's induction? If then?"

Adora scoffed, sounding as much confused as frustrated. "And what, suddenly you give a damn?"

"I don't! I shouldn't! You fucking left me!" Shouting in the stacks was a bad, bad idea, and it was only through genuine fear for their lives that Catra managed to strangle her voice down to a strained rasp. "You left me. But unlike you, I keep my promises. I'm not leaving you. I haven't *forgiven* you, Adora. But I'm not leaving you to die."

With tears in her eyes, Adora stepped forward, crowding Catra back against the carrel wall. Catra's heart, already pounding, threatened to stop entirely when Adora touched their foreheads together, her hitching breaths washing over Catra's face.

"I miss you so much," Adora whispered.

Catra swallowed hard, reached half-successfully for nonchalance. "What, Huntara's bulging muscles and bad-girl vibes aren't enough for you?"

"Why do you keep talking about Huntara? She has nothing to do with this! I mean, she's on the team, but that's all…"

Huntara was on the team. Adora was taking her into danger, which didn't make sense if the point of the mission was to protect Huntara from the Graduation Horde. Shouldn't she be convincing Huntara not to—

Oh.

"You don't—" Catra had to stop and swallow again. "You're really not doing this for her?"

"I already told you, I'm doing it for *you*. Which is why it's stupid for you to come, you need to stay where it's safe and—"

Catra grabbed her face and kissed her.

Adora made a tiny surprised noise. Then, after a terrifying moment of stillness, she leaned into the kiss, fumblingly wrapping her arms around Catra's waist and back. Catra slid her arms around Adora's neck, pulling her closer.

It wasn't perfect and magical like in Catra's dreams. It was uncertain and clumsy—and warm and real and *Adora*, and that was more than perfect enough for Catra.

Until she pushed the kiss just a little further, not even meaning to, parting her lips and shifting Adora's open just a bit—

And Adora stumbled back, gagging. Tearful and hoarse she said, "You taste like *malia*."

Catra felt like she'd been slapped. No, she'd been slapped before; this was infinitely worse.

"I'm sorry," Adora tried to say, but Catra cut her off.

"You backstabbing hypocrite," she spat. "Like I'm not exactly what you made me. Go die in the Graduation Hall, see what I care."

She ran, almost hoping a mal would be waiting to catch her.

Chapter 7

When someone knocked on Catra's door that evening, her heart clenched in mingled hope and dread that it might be Adora. She stared at the door until the knock repeated, and a voice called out —not Adora's. Glimmer's.

"Noticed you weren't at dinner, Catra. I brought you some food."

Catra growled under her breath, and strongly considered not answering. But she wouldn't put it past Glimmer to break down the door. "I'm not hungry," she shouted instead.

Glimmer's voice remained cheerful. "You gonna add 'lying to your friends' to your list of misdeeds?"

Catra snorted. "Since when are we friends?"

"Since now, if you'll open the door."

Catra's eyebrows flew upward, then drew down into a frown. One didn't offer friendship lightly in the Scholomance. There were no parents here, no teachers—friends and allies were all you had. To have a *friend* in New York Enclave… She couldn't help thinking it was the kind of pie-in-the-sky thing a maleficer might say to get inside a victim's room. But since getting deep into malia herself, Catra could smell it on others like never before. Glimmer's mana was as pure as a mountain stream—which was to say, there was a little mud and fish pee, but not enough to really hurt anything.

Catra opened the door.

Glimmer bustled in with a modest plate of food; one roll, two triangles of quesadilla, most of a fruit cup. It was more than she'd expected. The school didn't like anyone taking more than their share, even if it was to give to someone else.

Catra took the plate, narrowed her eyes at Glimmer, and started murmuring a poison-detection spell. Glimmer just chuckled and

began shamelessly checking out the room, running her eyes over the clawmarked mirror, legless bed, and sharpened broom handle with interest.

No poison. Catra shoved an entire wedge of quesadilla into her mouth, abruptly conscious of just how hungry she really was.

"So, *friend,"* she said after she'd chewed and swallowed, "cut to the chase. How much did Adora tell you?"

"She did a lot more crying than telling."

Good, Catra snarled internally. But under the vicious satisfaction was something more wistfully pleased, that Adora knew she'd hurt her and regretted it.

"But she did mention you'd called her a backstabbing hypocrite, presumably because you feel she forced you into malia use."

"I do *presumably* feel that way, yes." Catra showed her fangs briefly, before tearing into the roll. She itched to demand more answers, every word she could wring from Glimmer about how Adora was doing and what she was saying—but it wouldn't do to betray too much interest.

Glimmer heaved a sigh and leaned against the edge of Catra's desk. "I kinda didn't realize you were still holding the drained-crystals thing against Adora."

Catra stared at her. "Gosh," she said, deadpan. "Why would I still care about that."

"Yeah, well, you're holding a grudge against the wrong person. I'm the one who messed up your crystals."

So all of this, *all of this*, was *her* fault. Rage flared through Catra's body like burning magnesium. She snatched Glimmer up by the collar and slammed her against the wall—against the mirror, actually, barely restraining herself from shoving her out into the void instead.

"I'm really sorry. I swear I didn't mean to do it," Glimmer said, sounding miserable but—unexpectedly—not at all afraid. "I wouldn't do that to someone, even someone I didn't like. And if I did," a moment's crooked half-smile, "I'd steal the mana for myself, not hand it to the fucking *mals*."

"Oh, but if you stole it, it wouldn't be mana," Catra said in a mocking singsong, shaking Glimmer to smack her head into the mirror (*"Ow,* bitch!"), "it'd be *malia* and you're too good for that!"

Glimmer rubbed her head, and said thoughtfully, "Not convinced that's how it works, when you're not directly harming some living thing to get it. But regardless, I would have it in a pinch. Better a maleficer than dead."

Catra barked a bitter laugh. "Tell it to Adora."

Glimmer's voice was clear, steady, and heavy with meaning. "I have."

Catra blinked. Surely she was imagining the hint, the barest hint, that Glimmer had *defended* her to Adora?

Her hands loosened on Glimmer's collar, white-hot rage dimming to an orange ember-glow. If she were honest with herself—for once—she could admit she'd already figured it was Glimmer who damaged her crystals.

Her own reflection peered at her over Glimmer's shoulder. *Are we committing intentional murders now?* it seemed to ask. *Starting with one of the few people who's ever* apologized *for doing us wrong?*

No. And if she wasn't going to follow through on a threat, best to stop making it.

Catra stepped back from the mirror, managing to shove Glimmer one more time in the process.

"Adora," Catra said, her voice a little shaky with lingering adrenaline, "has never used one drop of malia. Not once."

"She's never had to."

Right? Catra wanted to shout. *She has no idea what it's like to be desperate, to* need *more power than she has!* Her last ember of rage flared up—and burned out. Catra sighed and spoke the truth she knew in her soul. "She still wouldn't, though. She never would."

Glimmer nodded sympathetically. "Yeah. Bow's strict mana, too. And Perfuma."

Catra cracked an ironic smile. "How do you know when a wizard is strict mana?"

In unison they answered, "Don't worry, they'll tell you!" and burst into laughter. It was a shock, to hear herself laughing, for all that the sound was a little too loud and high-pitched.

Glimmer brushed past her and dropped onto the bed, bright and casual. As if they were friends. Which, technically—in a transactional sort of way—they were.

On the list of people Catra had ever wanted to be friends with, Glimmer was near the bottom. And yet… it was such a relief, knowing someone who actually *got it*. Shame it had to be the worst sort of enclaver—a Domina's daughter!—but that was just Catra's usual bad luck.

"Not that I don't see where they're coming from, about malia," Glimmer was saying. "It's not just about the moral high ground, or even the anima damage. You're contributing to the problem, even if you're not killing anything worse than bugs and weeds. But so many other people are doing it, it's hard to believe your own little drop in the bucket matters at all…"

Catra warily sat down on the other end of the bed, picking up her dropped plate. "Contributing to what problem?"

"You know, the maleficaria problem." Glimmer squinted at her, watching for some sign of comprehension, perhaps, and not finding it. "Catra… crap, you were raised by a maleficer, weren't you? Of course *she* never told you."

Catra clenched her teeth, hating Shadow Weaver all over again. "Told me what?"

"Where mals come from. What creates them."

"Some are creature experiments gone wrong, or constructs that got too independent…"

"Yeah, some, but..." Glimmer grimaced, the sad and pitying expression of someone delivering bad news. "But mainly it's malia that creates them. Every time someone pulls malia, it's a drop in some cosmic bucket that overflows into maleficaria, sooner or later. One of those balancing-the-universe things. In taking someone else's mana, you help create something that wants to take *your*s."

Something cold and sick squirmed in Catra's stomach. Half-consciously, she folded her blackened fingertips out of sight.

"How much malia does it take to make a mal?" she asked hoarsely.

"I don't think anyone really knows. Probably depends on the mal."

God. Were there any mals Catra had created all by herself, out there right now, killing kids who'd never touched malia in their lives?

"Everyone knows about it, but no one likes to talk about it," Glimmer said. "No one likes to *think* about it. Because almost everyone cheats now and then. And tells themselves they're not really hurting anything." Her gaze went a little distant, and Catra thought about that little bit of mud in the mountain stream of Glimmer's mana.

"Anyway, are you going to eat that fruit cup?" Glimmer chirped suddenly. Catra hissed and snatched the fruit cup out of her reach. Glimmer laughed and flopped back onto the bed, stretching out lazily.

Catra tipped up her fruit cup, swallowing its juice-slick contents in one gulp. "Don't get too comfortable there, Sparkles. It'll be curfew soon enough."

Glimmer sighed gustily. "One of the worst things about this place is that you can't have sleepovers."

You technically could, of course, but only if you were suicidal. If you were inside someone else's dorm room at curfew, you basically got every mal in the school thrown at your head. The idea, apparently, was to keep the stronger kids from stealing others' better-located rooms. For instance, the freshman dorms on the top level were the safest in the school, and thus were given to the weakest and least experienced students; the school aimed to keep it that way.

"I grew up constantly having sleepovers with my friends," Glimmer continued. "Mostly Bow. Sometimes because we were happy, sometimes because we were sad… I hate that I always have to be alone at night, here."

"Personally, I put the mortality rate and bad food higher on the list," Catra said, knowing it was a lie. Her eyes felt hot as she thought about how she used to curl up in Adora's bed between classes—even when Adora wasn't there—just to be surrounded by her scent. And what a paltry replacement that was for how they'd grown up, a constant kitten-pile of two. She pulled her feet onto the bed and held her knees against her chest, tail-tip twitching.

Glimmer was watching her curiously.

Catra cleared her throat. "I guess we used to do 'sleepovers' with the other kids sometimes. When they came over for training."

"Other kids?"

"Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle. They're from other indie families in Michigan. They'd come stay for a week here, two weeks there…"

"For training," Glimmer said. "By the Black Witch of Detroit."

Catra shot her a glare. "*Anyway*. We all slept in one room, which was… a madhouse, but kind of fun. We'd play tricks on Kyle…" Kyle, her first malia victim, staring at her in shock as if she'd betrayed him. Because she had. Catra tore her mind away from the thought, suddenly flustered. "Usually the others ended up yelling at me and Adora to shut up and go to sleep. Which we didn't." Shit, she was rambling. She looked away, face heating.

Glimmer looked positively charmed, casually pulling her own knees up in mirror of Catra's posture. "I bet you'd tickle and poke and whisper at each other all night. Right? What kind of things did you talk about?"

That did not help the heat in Catra's cheeks, since the first thing to come to mind was the hushed, wide-eyed conversations they'd had after Lonnie told them where babies came from.

Glimmer was waiting for an answer, so Catra just shrugged, still looking away. "You know. Whatever."

"Did Adora still thrash around all night and, like, sleep-fight? What is that about?"

Catra whipped her head around so fast her neck popped. "What do *you* know about it?"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. "She naps in my room sometimes, when she's hurt or sick. So she has someone to take care of her."

Hurt? Sick? When had this happened? Catra nearly choked on belated worry and raging jealousy. "Yeah," she said curtly. "Adora can't even relax when she's asleep."

"Hmph. Pot and kettle, there." Before Catra could react to that, Glimmer stretched ostentatiously—a move that showed off her

plump and huggable boobs, Catra couldn't help noticing—and flopped onto her side. "I can relax *anywhere*. So if you need a role model, look no further."

Catra snorted. "Only enclavers get the luxury of relaxing, Sparkletits."

"What did you call me?" Glimmer bolted upright, and Catra had a moment of *oh shit*—but no, Glimmer was *laughing*, nearly shrieking with it, her eyes starting to water.

"Adora always said you had a great sense of humor," she wheezed. "I never really believed her."

"Too bad I don't have much sense of humor about being abandoned, betrayed, judged, insulted, and, and—toyed with." *You taste like malia.*

"Hey, now," Glimmer said, still half-laughing, "I told you the crystals weren't her fault."

Catra crossed her arms. "Did you think that was my *only* problem with Adora?"

"What other problem would you have?"

She made me think she loved me. And then snatched it away. Twice. Twice*, she's done that.* What came out of her mouth was only, "She joined an enclave," though that part seemed almost trivial now, next to—next to the other thing.

Glimmer still looked significantly more amused than she should be. "Are enclaves really *so* bad? Most people seem happy enough to join one." A truly impressive understatement, for a privilege people would and did kill each other for.

Catra growled deep in her throat. "When did you last work a maintenance shift, huh, Miss Domina's Daughter? When's the last time you had to stop and build mana before you could finish your homework, and hope nothing attacked you until you could build

more? Have you *ever* had to sit near a vent? Or skip a shower because no one would go with you to the bathroom?"

There was no trace of laughter in Glimmer's face now.

"I don't think you people even realize how many other kids' bodies you step over on your way out of here. Your parents don't tell you, I guess, any more than Shadow Weaver told me about mals and malia. But Adora—Adora *knows*. And apparently that wall of bodies doesn't matter to her, if she can just get on the right side of it."

Wonderingly, Glimmer said, "You're truly not jealous at all, are you? You're not just… sour that Adora didn't take you with her. You truly don't think she should have joined."

"Surprise," Catra said caustically. "Not everyone is panting after an enclave spot. Try not to faint with the shock."

"Huh." Glimmer's expression was difficult to parse—admiration? calculation? a weird, haunted gladness?—but it certainly wasn't disapproving. "Good for you."

The curfew warning bell rang.

Glimmer sighed. "Time flies."

Catra gave the traditional reply, albeit sardonically. "Better than lyeflies."

"You ain't lying." Tradition satisfied, Glimmer fought up to her feet from the floor-bed. Catra rose with perfect, smirking grace, and followed her to the door.

Glimmer opened the door a crack and absently checked for threats in the hall. "For the record, I've worked every single one of my own maintenance shifts." Before Catra could respond to that, she added, "Should we expect you at tomorrow's planning meeting?"

"You shouldn't expect me, full stop. Ask anyone."

Glimmer snorted. "Yeah, you're practically the Spanish Inquisition."

"I have some of their spells, actually. Wanna see?" Catra made sure to show her fangs when she smiled.

Glimmer looked unsettled, for the briefest moment, which did Catra's heart good. "Save it for the Graduation Horde, hm?"

"Hm," Catra said noncommittally. "'Night, Sparkles."

She closed the door over Glimmer's mildly irritated face, then stood staring at the metal surface for a minute. She didn't know how to feel about her new *friend* Glimmer.

Right now, she didn't know how to feel about anything.

"Adora!" Glimmer's voice was impatient, after the third time she caught Adora glancing toward the library doors. Adora quickly turned her attention back to the figures and diagrams on the library table. What had they been talking about? Right, artificers.

"Of course we need enough to accomplish the objective," she said to the gathered team, "but we have to balance that with having too many to effectively defend—"

A husky female voice murmured something in the crowd, and Adora glanced over mid-word. No, still not Catra. Deeply annoyed at herself, Adora turned firmly back to the plans. "Effectively defend," she repeated. "Fighters, though, I think we probably can't have too many of."

"But today's the last day to join up, if you intend to do it," Glimmer said, this time addressing the library crowd. "We need to know who we've got and what they can do, with time to plan and practice together."

Yes, because everything had to go perfectly, or they would all die. So Adora could not remotely afford to be distracted by Catra's absence. Glimmer had already told her not to count on Catra showing up. And anyway, she didn't *want* Catra going on this insanely dangerous mission. Her not being here was a good thing. So it was time to get her head in the game.

Catra's hands on either side of her head, pulling her down to trap Adora's lips against her own—those warm radiant moments of breathtaking intimacy, like she and Catra were twined together at the atomic level—

Before Adora ruined it.

In her defense, it was hard not to react to a blast of rotten, filthy malia across her senses. Adora wasn't especially sensitive to malia, even below-average at detecting it—so it wasn't until Catra's breath touched her mouth that Adora felt it at all. Then she suddenly felt it a *lot*, a taste of death and decay so intense, it was a wonder she hadn't thrown up.

Because Catra was a maleficer. She preyed on other people, and she wasn't going to stop. *Couldn't* stop, apparently; Entrapta had matter-of-factly mentioned that Catra couldn't use mana at all now. Not many people could come back from that.

Which meant that even if Catra made it through graduation, she was almost certain to die young and in agony as her guts rotted inside her. Unless she leaned into it, becoming the kind of maleficer who left a trail of bodies behind her, a horror story told in whispers for decades to come.

Both those thoughts were unbearable, which at least made it easier for Adora to stop thinking about them. She needed to focus on finding a way for everyone to survive the Graduation Hall.

Catra didn't show for the next meeting either, or the one after that—and suddenly, it was the day before graduation, the repair team

set to deploy first thing in the morning.

"Catra hasn't even talked to you and Entrapta?" Adora asked Scorpia, as the final meeting broke up.

"Not really, no," Scorpia said, wringing her hands—pincers, rather. "But she must plan to say goodbye, right? She knows that one way or another, me and 'Trapta aren't coming back…" As seniors, they would be headed straight out the gates after the repair mission.

"I'm sure she figures she'll see you in the Graduation Hall, since she's going too," Adora said lamely. She knew Catra was smarter than that. With the head start Scorpia and Entrapta would have, they'd probably be through the gates (or dead) before Catra even got into the hall. And fighting through a horde of mals—still a possibility, if the repair mission failed—was hardly the time and place for goodbyes, anyway.

"Did, um… did she ever get a graduation alliance?" Adora asked hesitantly.

Scorpia shook her head, wringing her pincers even harder. "I've been looking on the wall every day. Usually a few times a day. Don't see her name anywhere."

"Well, if this mission turns out well, she won't need an alliance," Adora said, "because all the mals will be dead."

Scorpia straightened her spine. "Yes! That's right!"

Adora clapped her on the shoulder, or as close to it as she could reach. "Go get some sleep, and be ready for tomorrow!"

Adora couldn't sleep, of course. It wasn't even because she was nervous about the next morning. She was terrified, of course, but she'd gotten used to repressing and working through fear before

she even came to the Scholomance. No, it wasn't the fear of death—or worse, failure—that was keeping her awake.

It was Catra.

It was the betrayal in her eyes when Adora joined the enclave. It was the hundred times they'd saved each other's lives. It was the memory of holding and comforting each other when Shadow Weaver was at her worst, and the feeling of the Scholomance induction spell pulling their clasped hands apart. The joy of finding each other again in the freshman hallway, as if they'd been apart for days instead of two or three minutes. It was the way Catra's laugh squeaked when she was extra happy, the way her tail bushed out when she was startled, the warm rasp of her voice as if she were always half-purring. It was the horror of watching her eyes gradually whiten, her hair and claws darken, as malia seeped deeper and deeper into her soul. The terror of holding her bleeding body on a bathroom floor, certain she was going to lose her any minute. It was, maybe more than anything else, the shock and joy and bone-deep goodness of kissing her in the library.

Adora got out of bed, tore a page out of one of her school notebooks, and wrote on it. Crumpled it. Wrote another one. Crumpled that one, too. Labored over the third one for half an hour, wiping tears before they could stain the paper. Carefully folded it and taped it shut.

Then she went back to bed and, desperate to be well-rested for the mission, sang herself the first lullaby that came to mind.

"You are my sunshine, my only sunshine…"

Around the time she got to *You'll never know, dear, how much I love you*, she drifted off to sleep.

"Remember to watch out for each other," Adora said, trying not to pace nervously as the team gathered in twos and threes at the

meeting point. "If anyone has to drop out of the shield spell, the ones on either side need to take on their share. If the shield fractures, Bow and Lucy, you leave the repairs to come shore it up. If it fails completely, don't panic, Netossa will get it back up and I will keep the mals off you as much as possible. Artificers, no matter what, no matter what you hear happening behind you—"

"Keep going with the repairs!" Entrapta shouted it like a cheer, pumping a fist in the air. She and Scorpia were just emerging from the stairwell, almost the last to arrive.

"Keep going with the repairs," Adora confirmed. No one had quite said it aloud, but they all knew—getting the repairs done was more important than any of their individual lives. If the repairs got done, even if they *all* died doing it… well, that was a lot better than everyone dying and *not* getting it done.

"You should let me come, Adora," Frosta said, half belligerent, half whining.

"You are absolutely not coming," Adora said firmly. "No one younger than a junior is going down there. Your inexperience damages *everyone's* odds of coming out again."

"Besides, sweetie, you and Double Trouble have a really important job up here," said Scorpia, patting Frosta's shoulder. Adora expected Frosta to bristle at "sweetie," but she and Scorpia had actually really taken to each other; she accepted the endearment without issue.

"We really do, hon," Double Trouble said in that smooth, slinky voice that always made them sound insincere even when Adora was pretty sure they were being genuine. "If all of this goes to hell—or heaven, I won't presume on the state of your souls—you and I might be the only reason *anyone* in the school survives."

Their route down to the Graduation Hall was a maintenance shaft, one that wasn't on the school's blueprints and didn't always exist; that was the only reason mals hadn't already used it to come

boiling up into the school. Without someone to seal it shut behind the repair team, that could change in an eyeblink.

They were still waiting for one of the artificers, so Adora had time to notice that Scorpia, smiling and misty-eyed, was gazing down at something in her hand. (She'd glamoured herself one hand, in case she needed to grab someone without crushing them, and left one pincer for better mal-fighting.)

"What's that?" Adora asked, stepping closer.

Entrapta was the one who answered. "We both found one slipped under our doors after dinner last night. We think they're from Catra." She held hers out.

It was a tiny strip of eat-me paper, the fragile and nearly transparent sheets that could hold spells and impart them to whoever swallowed them. On it, in Catra's handwriting, were the words *good luck*. Not just in Catra's handwriting, Adora realized, but in Catra's *blood*. Blood freely given being, at this point, the only way Catra could use clean mana for the spell.

"Near as I can tell," Entrapta continued, "it contains a spell that really does improve luck, for a few hours."

"These would have been… hideously expensive." Both the eat-me paper and the spell. Adora didn't know what in the world Catra could have traded for them. Lots more blood, maybe. Her voice softened. "She really cares about you guys."

"I guess she does." Scorpia wiped her eyes with the back of her pincer.

It was beneath her, Adora told herself firmly, to be jealous that Catra had found other friends to care about. After all, Adora had done the same. And it wasn't jealousy, really. Adora just… would have liked to be on that list of friends.

"Time to eat, Scorpia," Entrapta said, and placed her strip of paper on her tongue. Scorpia quickly followed suit.

The last artificer arrived, welcomed into his pack of fellows with great relief.

"Form up," Adora ordered, and turned to Frosta for one last thing. "Please hold onto this for me."

Frosta raised her eyebrows on seeing what was written on the outside of the sealed note. *For Catra, if I don't come back*. Frosta straightened; as Adora had hoped, being entrusted with something so personal helped mollify her about being left behind. "You can count on me, Adora."

"And me, of course," Double Trouble drawled.

Adora snorted. "Exactly as far as I can throw you."

The lizard chimeric's smile widened. "Fortunately, you're very muscular."

"Just get the hatch sealed, DT."

Adora took her place at the head of the group. *If Catra ever sees that letter,* she thought, *it'll be because I never see her again.* No, she didn't have time for that. She drew in one deep breath. On the exhale, she shut off all emotion in favor of focus and clarity.

They headed into the maintenance shaft, and down toward the Graduation Hall.

Catra had attended every planning meeting, of course, veiled by a spell that made her blend indistinguishably into the crowd. She knew where and when the repair team was forming up. At least, she thought she did. Until she stepped out of the stairwell into a nearly-empty corridor.

"Where are they?" Catra demanded.

Frosta made a noise of inarticulate anger, and Catra realized she and Double Trouble had been in the midst of casting something,

their hands outstretched toward a hatch in the wall that Catra had never seen before. The occasionally-existing maintenance shaft, she assumed.

"They're underway and into the breach, darling," said Double Trouble.

Frosta huffed and dropped her arms. "What are you doing here, Catra?"

Catra crossed her arms, ears pressed flat. "I just… wanted to wish them luck." Rather literally; the last strip of eat-me paper with the shockingly expensive luck spell was tucked into an envelope in her pocket. She'd only just finished paying Jingye for it—she couldn't afford to lose more blood, but she'd given him her purification spell and helped him set it in some more eat-me paper.

Double Trouble shrugged. "Well, I'm afraid you missed the boat."

"You can't go down there, you know," Frosta said, eyes narrowed suspiciously. "You haven't been in the plans, you haven't practiced with them. It's like a graduation alliance, you'd just gum up the works and get people killed."

"I know the plans," Catra said impatiently, "and I don't need practice to work with Adora. But I wasn't going with them anyway."

"Good. 'Cause our job is to seal up this hatch, and we're doing that now." Frosta raised her hands again and cleared her throat at Double Trouble.

"Wait," Catra snapped in alarm. "How are they getting back out, if you seal the door?"

"Oh, I thought you *knew the plans*—"

Double Trouble, perhaps seeing the odds of their death or maiming in Catra's face, interrupted. "Little Miss Glimmer will be

bringing them out with a teleportation spell. It was just decided last night, when she finally had a successful trial run."

Catra stared. "They're basing everyone's survival on a spell *one* person has used successfully *one* time?"

"You'll notice I'm up here, darling, not down there."

"The spell works fine," Frosta said impatiently. "Glimmer just had to figure out how to use it on so many people at once."

"And if Glimmer gets killed down there?"

"We all know the spell now. Hopefully someone else can cast it."

"Hopefully."

"We *have* to be able to seal the hatch!" Frosta said. "Otherwise—especially once Adora starts killing them right and left—the mals are going to start coming up it."

"That won't matter much if the machinery's repaired," Catra pointed out. "The Cleansing will get them on this floor as easily as down in the hall."

"If," Double Trouble said, in precise imitation of Catra's *hopefully*.

Catra paced back and forth across the hallway, pinching the bridge of her nose. "They left early, dammit. I can't believe I missed them."

"I think Adora couldn't believe it either," DT observed. "She left you a note."

Catra's eyes snapped to DT's so fast, she could feel her pupils dilate. "Where?"

Double Trouble jerked their head at Frosta.

Frosta shifted uncertainly. "Well… I'm not supposed to give it to you yet. Maybe not ever."

Catra stepped forward with her hand out, and said probably the last thing either of them expected her to say. *"Please."*

Frosta glanced at Double Trouble, who gave her an encouraging look that did not seem to make her feel any better. But she drew a taped-shut paper from her pocket and handed it to Catra.

On the outside, Adora had written, *For Catra, if I don't come back.*

Catra turned away from the other two, for whatever bit of privacy she could get (later she'd be appalled to remember she turned her back on Double Trouble, of all people) and cut the tape on the paper with one claw. Her hands were *not* shaking. Much.

Catra,

I love you.

Her breath stopped. There were more words written, but for a long moment she couldn't look away from those first three. Adora couldn't mean it the way she wanted her to mean it, but it almost didn't matter.

Catra,

I love you. I'm so sorry I ever made you doubt that. I can't be sorry I joined New York—they're my family, and I've been able to help so many people who would have died otherwise. But it kills me that I lost <u>you</u> in the process. I don't like the choices you've made, but I wasn't the one who had to make them. I know you felt like you had no options, and maybe you didn't, and maybe that's partly my fault. No matter what's happened, or what happens now—no matter how much we've hurt each other—I love you. I always will.

I wish I'd gotten another chance to kiss you.

Yours,
Adora

Catra swayed, caught the wall to keep herself upright. She could feel something breaking, or melting, or shattering, inside her chest. Some poisonous thing she'd been hugging to her like a treasure was just… crumbling away. It hurt, like blood returning to a numb hand.

And Adora hadn't had the guts to say any of this in person. Maybe wouldn't have *ever* said it, only left it in a goddamned *note* like a reminder to buy bread. Words on paper instead of spoken, left behind to just torture Catra forever once it was too late to do anything about them. How could she *do* this? Catra was going kill her for this.

Her hand spasmed, crinkling the letter; she quickly smoothed it out, folded it back into its original creases, and tucked it away. She pulled out her last good-luck spell paper and put it under her tongue. There would be no practical way to give it to Adora now, and she was going to need it herself.

She'd never eaten a spell before. It just tasted like paper, and a hint of blood—maybe a touch of vanilla?—and yet she did feel different, somehow. A little more relaxed, a little less afraid. As if she had hope that things would be okay.

Maybe that was just the letter. *Yours, Adora*.

She turned back to face Frosta and DT, who were watching with frowns and raised eyebrows, respectively. "I'm going down that shaft."

Frosta looked exasperated. "We have to *seal* it—"

"Then seal it behind me."

Frosta looked uneasy. "Catra… Glimmer hasn't practiced teleporting you, she might not be able—"

"And if I yank all your mana," Catra growled, "you won't be able to seal the door at all, will you?"

Frosta glanced at Double Trouble, who just shrugged. "What are *you* willing to risk to stop her, princess?"

"Not a darn thing," Frosta decided. "Go on, then. We need to have this *done* already."

The hatch, Catra discovered, opened onto a long vertical tube containing nothing but ladder rungs punched into the metal wall. Perfectly silent and bearing no scent of mals, only the recent passage of a large group of terrified students. She almost thought she could separate Adora's scent from the crowd, bright and clean and familiar.

Catra climbed through.

The hatch closed behind her, glowed for a moment, and then disappeared, leaving the shaft lit only by a single bulb somewhere far, far above. Catra, armed only with her claws and what remained of her wits, started down the ladder into the dark.

Chapter 8

Catra spent most of the climb down the shaft reviewing any of her spells that could remotely be used for combat. She wasn't in great shape in terms of mana held currently in her body—she'd used a lot paying off Jingye—but she still had the better part of two crystals around her neck, and if there was ever a time to use what she had saved back in the dorm, it was here and now. Even if it meant she had nothing left later. There might not *be* a later.

When she reached the bottom of the shaft—telling herself her racing heart and shaky breath were only from the exertion of the climb—she found a door. She would not have liked to open it blind. But the repair crew hadn't wanted to, either, and luckily—for a moment she tasted blood and vanilla—the transparency they had cast, making a sort of porthole in the door, had not quite faded back to opacity.

She knew from the planning meetings that the machinery was located on the same wall as this door, a hundred yards to the left. When she craned her neck and pressed close to the door, she could see… about what she expected to see, really. Countless maleficaria, a heaving mass of them like maggots on a corpse, swarming the area around the machinery, held back only by the pale shimmer of a multi-person shield spell.

Wait, no, it wasn't just the shield holding them back. In fact, few of them were even making it to the shield, because first they had to get past Adora.

All she could see of Adora, from this angle, was the glowing iridescent flash of her sword as it rose and fell, slashed and chopped, unceasing, keeping a space of maybe six feet around the shield clear of mals. Absolutely no one else was wielding a weapon or casting combat spells. Absolutely no one was helping her.

The sheer number of mals in the Hall was terrifying beyond words, a flashback to Catra's worst nightmares about graduation. And no one was watching Adora's back.

Catra took a deep breath, and on the exhale, veiled herself in the blend-in spell she'd used to eavesdrop on the planning meetings. She stepped through the door.

She was overrun at once, mals crawling over and under and around her. It was all she could do not to scream, even though they were paying her no particular attention. Some were unspeakably horrifying to even see close up, much less feel pressing against her as they shoved their way through the crowd. Fighting not to retch, she started shouldering forward.

It went all right at first, though it was slow going. But then she tried to push away some pale, pulsating thing with chitinous legs, and it turned its insectoid head 180 degrees to lock all twelve of its eyes on her. Maybe it had some kind of mental powers. Maybe it was just smart enough to know that vanishingly few mals had *hands*. Whatever the reason, Catra had officially stopped blending into the crowd.

Luckily (*sudden taste of blood and vanilla*), the press of the swarm swept the twelve-eyed mal away before it could reach out for Catra. But she could see it trying to fight its way back to her. And other mals were noticing.

Trying to fight off this throng would be laughably insane. She had maybe a second to figure out what else to do.

She opened her mouth, and out came a spell she hadn't intended to ever use.

The tattered, bloodstained little book containing it had dropped into her hands several months ago. Assigned to make a truth serum, she'd asked the void for "ways to make people tell the truth." She probably—as a confirmed maleficer, especially—ought to have expected interrogation spells. She could not have

expected Spanish Inquisition *torture* spells. A few of which were so dark and nasty, they could *only* be cast with malia.

Well, she had plenty of that. And pure pain was way less expensive than actual physical damage. Pain was only in the mind, or at least only in the electrical impulses of the nerves.

Catra began screaming the spell as loudly and harshly as she could; the meaner she could sound, the better, for this one. It was written in very old-fashioned, elegant, even poetic Spanish, but it all boiled down to one simple cruelty. *Do what I want or I will keep hurting you*.

And what she wanted was for every single mal to get as far away from her as possible.

Immediately, mals were squealing, snarling, thrashing, climbing all over themselves to get away from her. Some collapsed or started seizing, in too much pain to retreat, but at least too incapacitated to attack. A very small amphisbaena straight-up dropped dead, and as with the mal that died in the drain full of acid, that was an unmitigated win for the students—but it felt wrong. The spell felt wrong, *all* of it felt wrong. It made her sick in a way even pulling malia never had.

Not least because part of her liked it. Liked the power, the cruelty, in a way she knew was… evil. There was no point using any other word. She hoped it was something the spell was doing to her, rather than something pre-existing that it was merely bringing to the fore. Either way, she desperately wanted it to stop.

Instead, still scream-chanting, she used it to plow through the mals and toward the machinery, waves of mals rising on either side of her like a Red Sea made of monsters.

She saw the moment Adora spotted her, her blue eyes going wide.

"Hey, Adora," she sang out, between verses of the torture spell.

"Catra? What are you—Get behind the shield, now!"

One of the students holding the shield collapsed.

The girl, Spinnerella, had been standing directly behind Adora when she turned grey and blank-eyed. She pitched forward and would have knocked Adora down—Catra could already see it happening, the wave of mals that would pour over them all the moment Adora was down. They would tear Adora to bloody shreds inside of a second, then break through the shield where Spinnerella had left a weak spot, and the whole lot of them would be one more repair team that was never seen again.

But that didn't happen, because Catra, her mouth tasting so strongly of blood and vanilla that it burned, caught Spinnerella before she could fall.

"Spinny! Spinny!" Netossa screamed, leaving her place in the linked-hands line to haul her girlfriend back behind the faltering shield. Catra had no idea whether the girl was unconscious or dead—it sure didn't look good—but she had other things to deal with. Even with total catastrophe averted, the incident had distracted Adora and caused the mals to surge forward.

Catra flung her electrocution spell at the nearest handful of mals, frying several to a crisp, but others bulled right through it. Her next-cheapest combat spell was an entanglement, which worked to trip up those electricity-resistant mals, but they were just bowled over and replaced at the front, so it didn't make much difference.

In the corner of her eye, she could see Adora's sword flashing as she fought back the entire pack of chayenas trying to get to Spinnerella's spot in the shield. The kids on either side had joined hands and were sharing Spinnerella's former burden between them, but one of them—Perfuma—had turned a little greenish, and the shield was still wavering the slightest bit. Adora had to concentrate on defending that spot—which limited her mobility, and left her left flank open to mals approaching from the other side.

Catra set her feet, claws digging into cement, and threw herself into keeping the mals off Adora's back.

The smart thing would have been to use the Inquisition spell again. This was no time for squeamishness. But when she tried, she gagged on the words, her stomach heaving and twisting. They *definitely* didn't have time for her to vomit. So she did the next-smartest thing, and threw a fireball.

Fireballs, one after another, took out a horka, a kvenlik, and two harpies before a castigator shoved its way to the front. Its slimy acid-dripping limbs were too wet to burn, and neither would the great big metallic scratcher beside it. She had to break out the expensive disintegrator spell, but at least she could dial it down to half-strength; most any mal she injured was immediately eaten by the others. She kept the fireball spell in one hand and disintegrator in the other, using the cheaper option when she could. Still she could feel her necklace crystals emptying as fast as her storage crystals could fill them—or faster. If she cast more than she could afford and fainted like Spinnerella, there'd be nobody to miraculously catch *her*.

She dialed the disintegrator down to a third, and focused on hitting faces and feet.

A rhysolite, moving low and slow, nearly got her before she registered the threat. A couple of its injectors left bloody scores down her leg when she kicked it off and reduced it to a puff of powder, but she didn't *think* any of its bone-dissolving venom had gotten into her bloodstream. She'd find out soon enough.

The rhysolite threw her off balance enough that a baby suckerworm nearly got her next, and wouldn't *that* have been embarrassing? She clawed it open and threw it back into the throng to be messily devoured.

The fragile, squishy suckerworm reminded Catra that she did have a blunt-force spell, basic and crude because blunt force had never fit her style and that mattered in magic, but right now she only

cared that it was cheaper than fire. Guiding it with half-conscious stomping and slamming movements, she started smashing the softer or more spindly mals into paste left and right.

But a voracitor was too sturdy to smash, and behind it—

Holy shit. What she had taken for three or four big, lumpy rock-type mals was all. One. *Argonet*. The thing had to have been in here feeding on other mals for years, because now it was too big to squeeze in through the gates, much less a vent or maintenance shaft. Its hard, shiny hide, like a titanium rhinoceros, would deflect fire like it was nothing, and most other spells too, according to their textbooks.

She almost forgot to disintegrate the voracitor before it could grab her, and *did* forget to dial down the power, so that she was left gasping and weak-kneed. All three necklace crystals were dim and flickering, straining to bring in stored mana as fast as she was using it.

Catra knew she was a good fighter, but her strengths were agility and speed, not brute force. She could escape an argonet, probably—but she couldn't hold one off.

Adora stepped between her and the advancing horde, flicking her sword almost contemptuously to bisect a charging naga on the way. "I've got this, Catra. Get behind the shield."

Her voice was brisk, confident, not even out of breath. And Catra had to admit she'd reached her limit. She hissed, at her own weakness more than at Adora—saw the very edge of a fond smile on Adora's face as she did—and ducked through the shield.

She had paid little attention to what was happening in there until now. As she tried to catch her breath, her eyes traveled the mass of timeworn machinery taking up most of the wall. The artificers were on it like ants, replacing parts, cleaning out gears—but fully half of them were gathered in one spot, where a panel was open and someone had crawled inside until only their feet were visible.

She could dimly hear Entrapta's voice echoing, shouting to the other artificers to hand her this or reconfigure that.

"Hey, wildcat!" Scorpia waved as well as she could while still holding people's hands on either side. "What are you doing here?"

"Who cares?" Netossa snapped. "Catra, check on Spinny!"

Being *commanded* got Catra's hackles up, but it wasn't like she would behave any better if it was Adora lying on the floor. She dropped down next to Spinnerella and checked for a pulse.

"She's alive," Catra called, to a chorus of strained cheers and relieved sighs. "I think she's just crazy-low on mana." A feeling she knew—but with her combat efforts suddenly ceased, her necklace crystals had refilled with wild speed. She put a hand on Spinnerella's chest and started pushing mana into her.

Mana, not malia. She couldn't power a spell with mana, but just freely giving what she had to someone else—that was a better disinfectant than any purification spell. It was the same bemusing realization as she'd had when Jingye told her to put her blood on the eat-me papers. Clean mana wasn't entirely lost to her after all.

She couldn't help glancing across the Hall to the gates, due to open so soon now, a portal of light that would drop each lucky surviving student back where they came from—

A portal guarded by Horde Prime.

For a long moment, she couldn't pull her gaze away from the utter horror of it, the wet, glossy mass with too-many-eyes and too-many-mouths and soft, gentle tendrils squirming in all directions, seeking, seeking…

They were much too far away for even so large a mawmouth to reach them. She didn't have to look at it. She forced herself to turn away, and looked at Adora instead.

Adora had just pulled her sword free of the argonet's head, and turned to take care of the smaller mals who tried to sneak by in her distraction. As always, she struck with a deceptive grace that made you forget how heavy the blow would fall. Her hair—longer now than Catra had realized—was coming down from its ponytail, but wasn't soaked in sweat like Catra's mane. And there wasn't a scratch on her that Catra could see, whereas Catra was bleeding in four places, only two of which she remembered. Adora looked as fresh and easy as if she were warming up in the gym.

Her red jacket was glowing white now, probably from whatever enchantments it held. Frankly Adora looked like she was glowing all over; she had to be nearly drowning in mana with all the mals she was killing. Were her *eyes* glowing? The light made them a lighter, icier blue than normal. For a moment, as she delivered a particular brutal final blow to the fleshless skull of an ossitor, she didn't look human at all. There was almost a blankness to her, a cool and remote serenity.

And then Adora was Adora again, cocky and grinning, spinning her sword in her hand before chopping all three heads off a kerberos in one go.

Catra shook her head in bewildered awe. Not only did Adora *not* look like she'd been fighting for her life all this time without pause, she looked like she was having *fun*.

Spinnerella was just beginning to stir when the artificers suddenly began whooping and cheering in a variety of languages.

"It's working!" Entrapta cried in a gleeful mad-scientist tone. "It's working!"

Holy fuck, had they actually done it? Had they actually fixed the machinery? Some of the gears were moving…

Bow hopped down from something high on the wall that he'd been screwing into place. "Glimmer, we're done! Let's go!"

Catra hadn't even noticed Glimmer standing a few feet away, at the center of the line holding up the shield. At Bow's words, her eyes lit.

"Okay, form up!" she shouted. "Artificers, get in the circle! Catra, you too. Scorpia, get Spinny. We stop feeding the shield and switch to the teleport spell in three—"

Only half-sure what was happening, Catra let herself get pulled into the circle—a full circle, now, not half of one ending at the wall—with Scorpia on one side of her and Mermista on the other.

"Two!"

"What do I do? In the spell?" Catra hissed.

"Just contribute mana and hold on tight," Scorpia said. "There's enough of us to do the rest!"

"One!"

Catra wasn't sure how much mana she had left to contribute, but she was hardly going to be stingy about helping get out of here. She added her share to the swift current gathering around Glimmer, who had moved into the center of the circle, eyes closed and hands open.

The shield hadn't fallen yet, but it was fading, in favor of another spell covering almost the same area. Something less strong but more flexible, and more—pink?

"Wait! What about Adora?" Catra cried, looked over her shoulder—Adora was still slashing and stabbing away.

"Adora, now!" Glimmer called at almost the same moment. "Adora, we're going!"

Adora didn't so much as glance their way. She was inching further into the mob of mals. Catra could only see her face in profile, but

it had gone funny again—unnaturally still, her eyes a hundred miles away.

Catra's skin went clammy. *She's not hearing us at all*.

"Adora!" Glimmer sounded frantic. Bow started calling out too, and Mermista, but Adora gave no reaction.

The shield was failing fast, and with Adora wandering further out, something was sure to get around her and break through it.

"I'll come back for her," Glimmer said, high-pitched and tearful. "Everyone join in on the second line of the spell—"

Adora had changed direction, Catra realized. Her sword strokes were absent-minded, perfunctory, though still precise and perfect. Unblinking, head cocked as if listening to distant music, she was headed straight for Horde Prime.

"Adora!" Catra screamed, wrenched her hands out of the others' grasps, and leaped out of the circle just as it swept everyone else away in a whirl of pink sparkles.

Adora had, fortunately, left such a trail of destruction behind her that Catra had time to get onto her feet with her shield bracelet up before anything attacked her. She didn't bother trying to fight anything, just let a few eldritch horrors bounce off her shield while she dashed to catch up.

"Adora, what are you *doing?"* she shouted as she grabbed Adora's shoulder and snatched her around.

Adora's sword swung for Catra's throat, slicing right through her shield. The shield at least slowed the blade enough that Catra could dodge backward, a last fading hint of vanilla on her tongue.

"Catra!" Adora's eyes were hers again, horrified and confused, nearly throwing the sword down—Catra caught the hilt and shoved it back into her hand. "What's happening?"

"You tell me! Why are you trying to walk into a *mawmouth?*"

"I don't know," Adora stammered, "I don't know, it's like it was—calling me—like it knew me—Catra, it knows things about me, things even I don't know—"

"Well, it's gonna know the sound of our eternal screams if we don't get the fuck out of here!"

Adora looked around, voice dropping to a whisper. "…How?"

Catra's stomach sank as she realized why they hadn't already been attacked as they spoke—they were now close enough to the mawmouth that the other mals, terrified, were hanging back.

An abundance of caution on their part, Catra thought. Horde Prime's questing tendrils hadn't shown any interest in them yet, as they surely would if there was food in easy range. All its hundreds of eyes were unfocused and drifting, its hundreds of mouths whispering and murmuring in a miserable but desultory way. But if the mals were worried, Catra was worried.

"Levántate, o tierra, y sírveme!" She pulled tall, razor-sharp spikes out of the floor in a ring around them, blocking both the mals and Horde Prime, at least for the moment.

Of course, that meant they were trapped, too. But it wasn't like they had a way out anyhow.

Catra drew a shaky breath. "Any chance we can just hang out in here until the gates open in, what… an hour?"

Adora laughed brokenly. They both knew an hour might as well be a year. And even then, if the machinery really was fixed, this place would be scoured by curtains of Mortal Flame before the gates opened.

Silently, they reached for each other's hands.

"I got your letter," Catra said.

Adora blew out a breath. "Remind me to punch Double Trouble when we get back."

"Yeah, I'll be sure to do that," Catra said. "When we get back."

"Did you, um… did you like the letter?"

"Yeah," Catra whispered, lacing their fingers together.

They could hear mals pressing against the spikes, slavering and growling, talons scrabbling.

"They'll come over the top soon." Adora's voice caught, tears sparkling at the corners of her eyes. God, she was so beautiful. "I'll fight them as long as I can. I'm so sorry."

Catra shrugged. "At least this way we get killed outright instead of joining Horde Prime's joyful collective."

Adora shuddered. "Thank you," she whispered. "For saving me from that."

"Well, as usual, someone had to rescue your ass," Catra said lightly, as if they didn't both know she'd sacrificed her life to do it.

Her hand in Adora's, Catra realized, was the malia-damaged one. Pain and darkness had spread past her wrist, just since she entered the hall. Probably thanks to the torture spell. Adora's touch didn't hurt it like most things would. More importantly, Adora wasn't shying away from touching it.

"Why did you follow me, Catra?" Adora sounded anguished. "Why didn't you go with the others?"

"Because I love you, dummy. I always have."

Adora let go of her hand, but only to throw both arms around her, hugging her tight. Catra hugged back twice as hard, and the tears she had been determined not to shed squeezed out onto her cheeks. She was so scared, she was *so scared*, but that faded

away with the warmth of Adora pressing against her, her scent and the beat of her heart. Catra wished something could take them out right now, quick and clean, so they would never have to leave this moment.

And then Adora kissed her, gentle but earnest, and Catra changed her mind. She wanted *this* moment, and the next, and the next. She tried to hold her breath and not blast malia in Adora's face, but Adora didn't seem to care that much, kissing her again and again, tangling her hand in Catra's hair—

Wait, that wasn't—

The thing that wasn't Adora's hand snatched Catra backward, slamming her against the wall of spikes, and then, unable to pull her through, started dragging her up. Catra screamed and kicked and struggled, claws tearing at the stone of the spikes to slow her ascent, and she knew, she knew what had her even before she saw the panic and despair in Adora's eyes.

Horde Prime.

It didn't matter now what she did. She could empty an entire machine gun into Horde Prime along with every spell she ever knew, and it wouldn't matter. Oh, God, she would trade anything she ever owned to have Entrapta's one-person grenade in her hand right now. But she didn't have a grenade, instead she had about three seconds before this one curious little tendril, winding deeper and tighter into her hair by the moment, pulled her over the spikes and into the mawmouth.

"Please," her voice came out choked, as if the mawmouth had her by the throat instead of the hair, "your sword, Adora, please, quickly, *please*—"

Adora screamed and lunged forward, and Catra instinctively closed her eyes—

She didn't feel a blade pierce her chest, or her throat. She felt a grip on her neck, jerking her head forward, and then hot pain

sweeping up the back of her scalp.

She fell free, and they both hit the floor hard, Adora rolling them until she could leap to her feet over Catra's body, a shield blazing from the gem in her sword's hilt—just in time to deflect the first wave of mals coming over the wall of spikes.

Catra lay stunned for a minute, watching horrible tangles of claws and teeth and tentacles sliding across the shield, inches from her face. Finally she sat up and touched the back of her head, which still hurt. Her hand came away covered in blood.

"You cut my hair, you dolt!" she shouted. "I'm practically bald!"

"You needed a trim anyway," Adora said, and started to laugh.

Then Catra was laughing too, both of them giddy and closer to sobbing, really, than laughing. Catra got to her feet and wrapped her arms around Adora, who released the sword—it remained hovering in the air, keeping up the shield—to return the embrace.

Horde Prime wasn't pursuing them; it was having its pick of mals at the moment, plucking up any that got too close in their fixation on Catra and Adora.

"How long will that last?" Catra nodded to the shield.

Adora took a deep breath, and said softly, "Not long. It takes a lot of mana."

"You were overflowing with mana, earlier."

"Yeah." Another slightly hysterical laugh. "I siphoned most of it off into the New York mana pool, like usual. Didn't even think about it."

And now she couldn't get it back. There was no one from New York to give it to her. No one to give her any mana at all except Catra, whose necklace crystals had stopped refilling. No reserves

left to tap. Adora could surely get more by killing some mals, but that would mean dropping the shield…

"Maybe it's for the best," Catra said, "that the mals will break through before Prime gets to us again."

"Maybe," Adora said hollowly.

Catra's head felt light, and she didn't even know if it was psychological or the shock of having no weight of hair. Or maybe blood loss, since a hot curtain was still running steadily down the back of her neck. She wasn't afraid anymore; all she could feel was relief that she wouldn't be part of Horde Prime for eternity.

That was all she felt concerning her own death, at least. For Adora—oh, she wished Adora weren't here, weren't about to die, too. At the same time, she couldn't help thinking, *At least we're together*.

"Hey," Catra said, turning Adora toward her. "I love you."

Adora wiped the tears off her face, then took Catra's hands in hers and leaned their foreheads together. "I love you, too."

They stood together, waiting, watching the shield start to fracture under the relentless onslaught of hundreds of maleficaria. Catra was surprised to hear herself purring. Beneath that, she could hear the cleansing machinery beginning to clank and groan and move. At least they could die being almost certain it worked, that it wasn't all for nothing.

The shield really was coming down now, bits breaking off it like glass, and despite herself Catra was suddenly afraid, burying her face in Adora's chest—

Glimmer appeared next to them in an explosion of pink sparkles, screaming at the top of her lungs. She grabbed them each by one shoulder and *pulled*.

And suddenly they were in Glimmer's jam-packed dorm room, gasping in a heap on the floor, and the school was filled with the echoing cacophony of the graduation bells.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

It's the real Flutterina, jsyk, not DT.

"I think it looks cute." Adora ran her fingers through the scant few inches of Catra's hair.

"It's your fault, so you'd better," Catra replied, as if she weren't purring and leaning into the touch.

"Ahem!" Glimmer pulled Catra's head back to its former position and resumed her careful trimming. It was going to look funny until it grew out a bit, no matter what they did, but Glimmer insisted she could at least even it up and give it a better shape to grow into. Catra had tried to demur, only to be met with a cheerful "What else are friends for?"

Glimmer had already done too much, a debt that left Catra twitchy and irritable. Not only had she rescued them from the Graduation Hall, she'd patched up their wounds and topped up their mana from the New York pool while they—and most of the repair team—rode out the Cleansing in her dorm room. At least there was every reason to believe the sheets of Mortal Flame sweeping through the corridors and classrooms were likewise scouring the Graduation Hall.

Then the Cleansing was over, and the whole school shook as the senior dorms began riding the gears down into the Hall, Graduation beginning in truth. Scorpia and Entrapta had to book it out of Glimmer's junior-level room and get into place. They'd paused only to kiss Catra's forehead and boop her nose, respectively, Scorpia in torrents of tears. Catra had been too weak and woozy to push them off, an embarrassment she might never recover from.

By now, Scorpia and Entrapta and all the other seniors had long since discovered whether or not the repair mission worked. Catra would have to wait until next year to find out if they'd made it out.

"I think that's as good as it's going to get," Glimmer sighed, setting down her scissors and comb. "Now get the hell out of my room. This afternoon is the safest the school will be all year and I'm not going to spend it cooped up with a couple of… honeymooners."

Catra blinked, only then realizing she and Adora were holding hands, fingers interlaced and thumbs brushing back and forth on each other's skin. She nearly blushed—until she realized that *Adora* was blushing, and it was much more fun to wink at her and watch her blush harder.

"God give me strength," Glimmer muttered, shooing them out the door, but Catra saw the hint of a fond and satisfied smile at the corner of her mouth. Smug little jerk, she'd probably seen this coming long before either of them did.

Silent, hands still clasped, they walked down the hallway toward Adora's room. Other students flowed around them, looking lighter and cheerier than they'd looked in months, some of them dressed up in ribbons and skirts that wouldn't be safe any other time of the year. Someone was already in the shower, enjoying the opportunity to do it alone. One of the artificers from the repair team was being hugged half to death by her friends, who had apparently just now found out she survived.

They'd made it to senior year, all of them. All but the ones who hadn't, of course, the ones who weren't here to rejoice—but this wasn't the day to think about that. One more year, and they were home free.

Catra felt a brief twinge, remembering her intention to graduate early—she was supposed to be *out* already, out there with Scorpia and Entrapta. But it had always been a stupid and half-baked

plan, undertaken almost solely to get away from Adora. She found she was perfectly content to stay, now, and go into Graduation with another year of education and practice under her belt. Even if she hopefully *wouldn't* have to fight her way out after all.

Even as distracted as everyone was by their own celebrations, Catra noticed more than one raised eyebrow as gazes caught her and Adora's clasped hands. For Saint Adora the Most Beloved to date anyone was big, big news, but a *maleficer?*

Former maleficer, Catra thought firmly, though with no idea how she was going to pull that off, seeing as the one glowing crystal on her necklace—Glimmer's charity—was all she had left in the world.

Adora ushered Catra through the door into her room, and oh, it still smelled like home. She closed her eyes, just breathing it in, while Adora locked the door and pulled up its usual wards. With her eyes closed, Catra could almost imagine the last term or so hadn't happened at all. Tears stung under her eyelids.

"Catra?"

Catra smiled and opened her eyes, found Adora watching her curiously. "Hey, Adora," she purred.

"H-hey. We, um…" Adora fidgeted, smiling through a rising blush (*God* she was beautiful). "We have a few hours, before the freshmen arrive."

"Yeah? How should we spend that time?" Catra said, and began backing Adora, wide-eyed but unresisting, across the room. The bed hit the back of her knees, forcing her to sit, and Catra climbed into her lap, kissing her with all the pent-up love her soul had ever held.

They almost missed Induction, rushing into the cafeteria just as everyone's ears began to pop, the school's air pressure adjusting to the sudden arrival of so many bodies. There was a beat of

silence, and Catra could imagine all too well the new arrivals staggering and gasping in their new dorm rooms. She remembered all too well the nausea and vertigo of being yanked most of the way out of reality and dropped into this deathtrap of a school.

Then doors began clanging open, footsteps clattering, as the new arrivals rushed down to the cafeteria for one of the Scholomance's few heartwarming traditions.

Everyone took care of the freshmen on Induction Day.

"I swear they're gettting smaller every year," Catra muttered, watching the sick, shaky, wide-eyed fourteen-year-olds being ushered into the center of the cafeteria.

"I guess they must be, since you haven't grown an inch," Adora said, and grinned when Catra hissed in reply.

A ring of protective older kids formed around the freshies, watching for mals—there were always a few, even after the Cleansing, and if anything would draw them out it was a large gathering of fresh meat. Others brought the new kids water and blankets, giving them hugs or pep talks. Adora had her sword out, eyeing the ceiling vents; Catra steered a stumbling, green-faced straggler into the center with her fellows.

After a few minutes, when everyone had calmed down a bit, the best part of the day began. Because the traditional gathering maybe wasn't *entirely* altruistic; induction was the only communication students had with the outside world. Freshmen often came in bearing messages and gifts.

"Glimmer, from New York Enclave? I have a package from your mom."

"Fadil Al-Amri? Where's Fadil Al-Amri?"

"I'm here from Greenland Enclave and I have a letter for Frosta!"

Catra didn't expect anything, personally; neither of them had heard from their foster mother since the end of their first year, when she sent a wafer of Quick Study for them to share. So she and Adora were both startled when a pink-haired chimeric girl with wings—butterfly? no, moth—tugged Adora's sleeve.

"You're Adora, right? Shadow Weaver said you'd have blonde hair and a big sword."

"Huh," Adora said. "I mean, yeah, that's me! She sent me something?"

"Yep!" The girl handed Adora a folded page no bigger than a business card. Even those few grams of weight would have cost something from this girl's weight allotment, everything she could bring in to keep herself alive for four years. Catra hoped Shadow Weaver had given her or her family something really good in exchange.

Almost timidly, Adora unfolded the paper, revealing lines of small, close-set words in a familiar handwriting.

"Are you Catra?" said the moth girl. "She said you might be here, too. It's great to meet you. I'm Flutterina!" She twirled, pink-and-yellow wings fluttering as if to illustrate.

"Of course you are." Catra shifted away to look over Adora's shoulder at the letter.

> *Adora, I pray you are safe, strong, and growing in power. I have no doubt you are doing me proud. Remain focused; do not let yourself be distracted by trivial teenaged concerns. And do not let yourself be distracted by Catra—by her presence or her absence. She is strong and clever, but also reckless and undisciplined, and it will not surprise me if you two have to walk different paths. In fact, that may be best for both of you.*

Catra snorted. "She figures I've probably gotten myself killed already."

"Yeah, probably," said Adora with a chagrined smile.

Catra turned back to the letter, absolutely not caring that Shadow Weaver had called her *strong and clever*, because that woman's opinion of her did not matter. Whatsoever. At all.

> *Remember to be wary of the enclaves; do not let them ensnare you to their service, however sweet their promises. They will betray you in the end.*

Adora was the one who snorted, this time. She glanced at Glimmer, squeezing Bow's hand as he smiled tearfully at a letter, presumably from his dads—at Mermista and Perfuma, exclaiming over a tiny vial of potion Mermista had received—at Frosta, hugging her freshman enclave-mate so hard that surely neither of them could breathe. Catra didn't doubt that Adora was thinking the same thing she was; that for all the enclavers' faults (and Catra could produce an alphabetized list of those at any time), she'd trust any of those five kids further than they'd ever trust Shadow Weaver.

> *Only one more year until you can take your proper place beside me as a partner in our work. Take care. Dear child, I trust you will not disappoint me.*

'Our work'? What work did she expect Adora to do with—or more likely *for*—her? Didn't matter, it wasn't gonna happen.

"She didn't even sign it," Adora said. "No 'Love, Shadow Weaver' or, heaven forbid, 'Mom.'"

"You had real moms," Catra reminded her. "That Shadow Weaver probably killed."

Adora clenched her jaw.

"Hey, what's that?" Catra pointed to a tiny brown speck affixed to the paper with a sparkle of mana.

"Oh, she told me!" Flutterina said excitedly. "It's a Cheerful Daisy seed! Whatever that is."

Catra lifted her lip, glaring at the seed.

"Cheerful Daisies are enchanted to purify the air wherever they grow," Adora told the girl, "and infuse it with… positive energy, I guess? The textbook says it lifts the spirits and clears the mind. And if you get dangerously sick, you can eat it—or ideally cook it into a soup—and it will almost certainly cure you. Just the once."

Flutterina's eyes were wide. "That sounds really valuable. She must love you a lot."

Catra smiled with deep, ironic serenity. "She knows I'm allergic to daisies."

"You keep it." Adora handed Flutterina the seed, letter and all.

The moth girl's jaw dropped. "Are you *sure?*"

"Yeah, are you sure?" Catra demanded.

Adora shrugged. "I can't use it, so she might as well."

"I mean, you *can*," Catra said. "We could just mostly hang out in my room, or—"

"No, that's ridiculous. I want you to be in my room any time you want." Adora smiled a little bashfully. "I just got you back, I'm not letting some *flower* come between us."

Weakly, Catra tried again. "You could trade it for some very big-ticket stuff…"

"I don't need any big-ticket stuff," Adora said dismissively, as only Adora could. "And you know how it works—someone brings in a letter for you, you're supposed to look out for them, get them started on the right foot."

Not usually a 'right foot' this big! But after all, this was Adora, who had been stupidly generous even back when she had nothing much to share, whose main motivation in joining an enclave was to help more people, give herself away more efficiently.

Adora was giving Flutterina instructions on how to grow the daisy; when the moth girl finally scampered off, Adora looked to Catra and said "What?", almost defensively.

"Nothing. You're just an idiot, that's all."

"Yeah, well, I'm *your* idiot."

Catra pulled her in for a kiss, brief and bright as a firefly. "Yes, you are."

"Breathe in the light. Breathe out the dark. Breathe in the light…"

Catra, sitting lotus-style on the floor of her dorm room, suppressed a twinge of impatience. She did not enjoy meditating, despite being fairly good at it, not to mention the breathing exercises and visualizations and other nonsense Perfuma had her doing. It all took so long and seemed so silly.

But she had stopped protesting it the day she realized her hand didn't hurt anymore.

It was still malia-black up to the wrist, and Perfuma said it might always be. But the deeper tissue damage had stopped. Had *healed*.

"I'm not any kind of expert at any of this," Perfuma had warned, when they made the agreement—Perfuma's help in exchange for Catra writing five spells of Perfuma's choice for her. "There are other people you'll want to consult with, after you graduate—there's this one indie healer in Wales, I've heard—but until then, I can at least help you start using mana again."

Which was kind of important, since she wouldn't be using malia anymore, ever. Any time she was tempted, all she'd have to do was think of the Inquisition torture spell, and hope she could hold onto her lunch.

If she'd still had storage crystals full of malia… but they'd all been emptied out by her little adventure in the Graduation Hall. Adora was helping her fill them again. Catra didn't want anyone's charity—but it didn't feel like charity from Adora, not now. It felt like it had before, when they shared everything without hesitation. Like they were best friends again, but better, because now they could kiss whenever they wanted.

"I want you to think of pure white light, running like water," Perfuma said, soft and slow. "Feel it running through you, warm and happy, carrying all the darkness and dirt away…"

Catra found herself thinking instead of the warm water of the shower, yesterday, where she and Adora had decided to replace bad memories with good ones. Her grin and happy shiver were probably not the correct response to this exercise.

Fortunately, someone knocked on the door before Perfuma could notice.

"Come on, Catra!" Glimmer called cheerily. "Bow's out of class now."

"Welp, duty calls!" Catra said, getting to her feet and dusting off her hands.

Perfuma followed her to the door, eyes narrowed. "If you're going to cut our session short, Catra, then you'll need to make up for it in your midnight meditation tonight."

"I will," Catra promised, and unfortunately meant it.

Perfuma opened the door and squeezed out between Glimmer and Bow, all exchanging cheerful greetings. Adora play-attacked her with the fat black marker she'd been swinging around like a

sword, because she was a giant dork, but Perfuma just blew her a raspberry.

"Oh, hey," Perfuma said, giving the marker a second look, "are you guys putting your names up?"

"Yep!" Glimmer chirped, already leading the way down the corridor to the stretch of wall between the boys' and girls' bathrooms. The place where students wrote down their graduation alliances.

"Hey, there's you! You guys made it official?" Bow was pointing at Perfuma's name, written below Mermista's and above—

"Sea Hawk?" Adora and Glimmer said together.

"He's very good with fire," Perfuma said defensively. "A little too good, really..."

"He's a screw-up," Catra said.

Perfuma sighed. "Sometimes his… intentions outrun his capabilities. But he has a very good heart, and a lot of tenacity, and believe it or not he knows how to come through when it's important. And, well… he's got it bad for Mermista, *and* he gets a spot in her enclave if we survive, so he's well-motivated to come through."

Catra paused mid-step for a moment, noticing another new trio of names on the wall. Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie. She wasn't sure why that made her happy, but it did.

"Here's a good spot," Adora said, uncapping the marker, and started writing—big, bold, almost childish letters. "Oh, Catra, Bow called you a 'rogue' earlier, I thought you might want to know."

"Oh, I was talking about how well-balanced we are as a group!" Bow said brightly. "We've got a paladin, a rogue, a ranger, and a wizard." He gestured toward Adora, Catra, himself, and Glimmer, in order. "It's a good party composition!"

"We're all wizards, Bow," Glimmer said, signing her name under Adora's with flourishes bordering on calligraphy.

"Yes, but that's not what I mean. Ugh, have none of you ever played an RPG?"

Adora frowned. "Like a rocket launcher?"

Bow sighed, signed his name in narrow, forward-tilted letters, and held out the marker to Catra.

"Nah, I got this," Catra said. She stepped forward with a claw extended, and carved her name directly into the metal, above Adora's.

"Somehow that seems like vandalism," Perfuma said thoughtfully, "when the markers don't."

Catra grinned. "Good."

They all stepped back and just looked, for a moment, at the little column of four names that meant they were a unit, a team, trusting and depending on each other. An alliance. *A princess alliance,* like she'd always so mockingly called them. Catra could only laugh at herself, looking around at the enclavers and near-enclavers she'd somehow ended up surrounded by.

She still didn't like enclavers. But she did like Glimmer, and Bow, and Perfuma, and maybe even Mermista, though she might never admit it out loud.

Most importantly, she also liked Adora, a little.

As if she'd heard the thought, Adora took her hand. "It's almost dinner time. Let's go ahead to the cafeteria."

"Sure. Oh, hang on. Left my light on." There was no reason to burn mana in an empty room. Catra trotted down the hall back to her dorm, cracked the door open, and clapped her hands, smiling as a spark of mana rose from her skin and turned off the lamp.

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